



2026 CFO Report

Compensation, Innovation, and Strategy Among PE and VC-backed CFOs

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Foreword

Charlie Walker

Founder & CEO, Harmonic Finance

In a period marked by rapid technological change, evolving capital markets and sustained pressure for growth, the role of the CFO in the United States has never been more critical. Across our work in the US market, one thing is clear: American CFOs are among the strongest in the world, commercially minded and growth-oriented leaders operating at the centre of strategic decision-making.

This edition of the CFO Report USA has been shaped by the insight and generosity of a remarkable group of finance leaders. We are grateful to our sponsors at Fidelity and Baker Tilly for their collaboration and perspective throughout the research, and to Chris Short of Harmonic for leading the design, execution and analysis of the survey itself. Their combined contribution has helped ensure the findings reflect the realities facing CFOs operating at scale in today's US market.

At Harmonic, our guiding principle remains to place with purpose. For us, that means working with CFOs who see their role not simply as financial stewards, but as commercial operators, strategic partners to founders and CEOs, and leaders who help businesses scale with intent. The data in this report reinforces that belief, while also shedding light on how US CFOs are thinking about compensation, equity participation and long-term incentives, and how these structures increasingly reflect the breadth of responsibility, accountability and value creation now expected of the role.

The insights that follow capture how finance leaders are navigating complexity, seizing opportunity and shaping the next phase of growth for their organisations. We hope this report offers both clarity and challenge, a snapshot of where CFO leadership stands today, and a prompt for how boards and executives should think about aligning reward, ownership and leadership impact going forward.

Foreword

Kristen Craft

Vice President, Business Partner Manager, Fidelity Private Shares

For nearly a century, many fast-growing companies have relied on Fidelity. We're excited to lean in on supporting high-growth, venture-backed companies even earlier with our cap table & data room product, Fidelity Private Shares.

CFOs at venture-backed startups and scale-ups are navigating a fundamentally different landscape than the zero-interest-rate era that preceded it. With lingering uncertainty in the fundraising environment and across the economy, generally, financial leaders are prioritizing cash runway preservation above all else. This may mean making difficult trade-offs between growth investments and financial conservation. Leaders are looking to extend cash runways through disciplined spending and detailed (but flexible!) scenario models that prepare companies for multiple futures. For many, the priority is clear: grow efficiently and preserve capital ahead of the next milestone.

Simultaneously, these CFOs are being asked to accomplish more with leaner teams and tighter budgets. This "operational excellence mindset" extends beyond simply implementing AI tools for automation, though that's certainly part of the equation. Finance leaders are hiring more deliberately, seeking versatile team members

who can wear multiple hats, and increasingly taking on responsibilities that span beyond traditional finance into operations, analytics, and strategic planning. The modern CFO typically needs to be a full-stack executive, comfortable context-switching between fundraising, FP&A, compliance, and strategic initiatives.

Finally, forward-thinking CFOs are cultivating relationships and building optionality for whatever liquidity event lies ahead. Whether positioning for an eventual IPO, acquisition, or becoming an acquirer themselves, they're developing connections across the ecosystem. They want to foster warm ties to investment bankers, potential acquirers, institutional investors, and advisors who can provide strategic guidance when critical decisions arise. The Fidelity Private Shares team is proud to play a role in this journey, supporting startup and scaleup success. We strive to support teams at all stages of growth with equity management and connection across the ecosystem.





Foreword

Travis Drouin

Managing Principal, Baker Tilly

As CFOs, you have long been at the intersection of innovation and financial discipline. The pace of change across industries demands not only agility but also a deep understanding of how finance functions are evolving across peer organizations. This survey report is designed to provide that insight.

In my experience, the most effective CFOs are those who look beyond their own organizations to understand broader trends—whether it’s the integration of AI into forecasting, shifts in capital strategy, or the changing expectations of finance talent. These insights help us benchmark our progress, challenge our assumptions, and make more informed decisions.

This report captures the voices of finance leaders across the startup and scaleup landscape, offering a snapshot of how our roles are transforming in response to market dynamics, regulatory shifts, and technological advancement. It’s not just about numbers—it’s about strategy, leadership, and the future of finance.

I encourage you to explore the findings with an eye toward action. Whether you’re navigating growth, managing complexity, or driving innovation, the perspectives shared here can help you align your finance function with the demands of fast-moving industries.

Thank you to all who contributed to this report. Your insights are helping shape a smarter, more connected future for finance.



Survey Overview

Survey Overview

Our CFO Survey 2025 captures the perspectives of US finance leaders. The findings reveal a profession in transition: nearly all CFOs (92%) expect AI to fundamentally or significantly change their role within 3-5 years, yet most remain in early-stage implementation.

Meanwhile, 88% of CFOs are expanding well beyond traditional finance, managing additional functions from HR to legal to strategy, reflecting the modern CFO's role as a cross-functional business leader.

Against a backdrop of economic caution, with 79% of respondents expressing neutral or negative sentiment about the economic climate, CFOs are making decisive choices: investing heavily in AI and technology while remaining measured on broader spending.

They're prioritizing culture and flexibility over compensation to retain talent, and focusing on organic growth strategies rather than aggressive expansion.

This report explores how today's CFOs are navigating compensation structures, adopting emerging technologies, building resilient teams, and positioning their companies for sustainable growth in an uncertain environment.



HARMONIC



Salaries, Bonuses & Equity



Nearly half of US CFOs (45.5%) earn over \$250,000 annually, with top earners exceeding \$400,000.

CFO base salaries demonstrate a strong concentration in mid-to-upper compensation bands, with the plurality split evenly between \$250,000-\$300,000 and \$300,001-\$350,000 (each representing 22.7%).

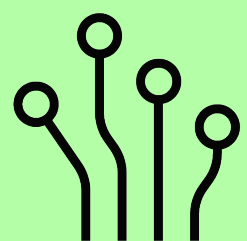
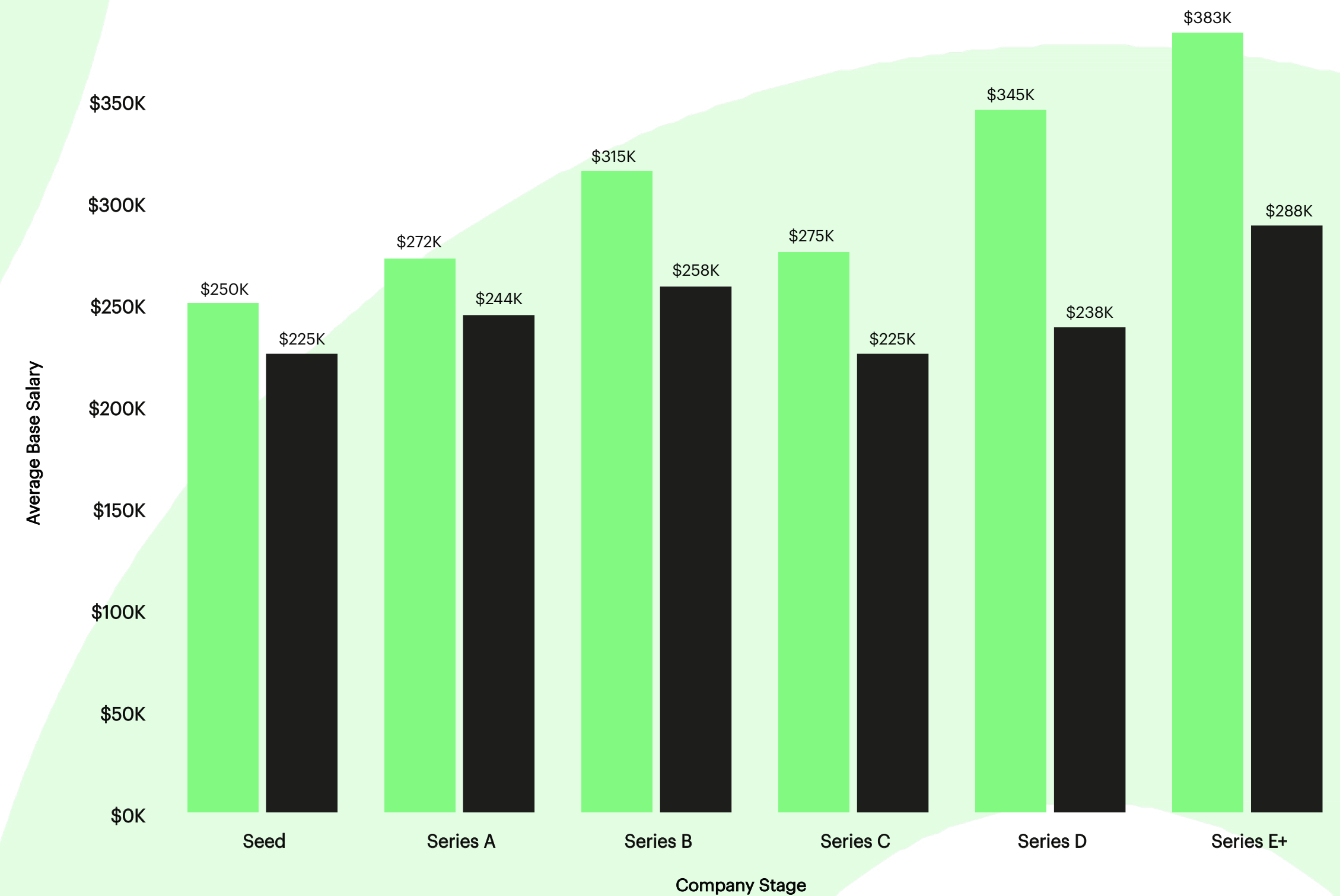
Seed-stage CFOs report an average base salary of \$250,000, rising to \$272,000 at Series A (+9%), and reaching \$315,000 at Series B (+16%). This progression continues at later stages, with Series D CFOs earning an average of \$345,000 and Series E+ CFOs commanding the highest compensation at \$383,000. While CFO compensation demonstrates overall upward trajectory across company stages, Series C represents a notable variance in the progression. This deviation reflects industry-specific

compensation dynamics, as Series C companies in the dataset span multiple sectors with varying salary structures, with top earners reaching \$375K.

The salary gap between CFO and VP Finance roles widens significantly as companies scale. At early stages (Seed through Series A), CFOs earn approximately 11-12% more than their VP Finance counterparts. However, this premium expands to 22% at Series B and C, and jumps to 45% at Series D.

Only 10.2% of CFOs earn below \$200,000, typically representing very early-stage ventures. An additional 15.9% earn between \$200,000-\$250,000, often indicating seed or Series A stage companies.

CFO vs VP Finance: Average Base Salary by Company Stage (Venture-Backed Companies, Permanent Employees)



CFO compensation in the Tech sector reaches up to \$450,000, with FinTech and DeepTech commanding premium compensation at the upper end.



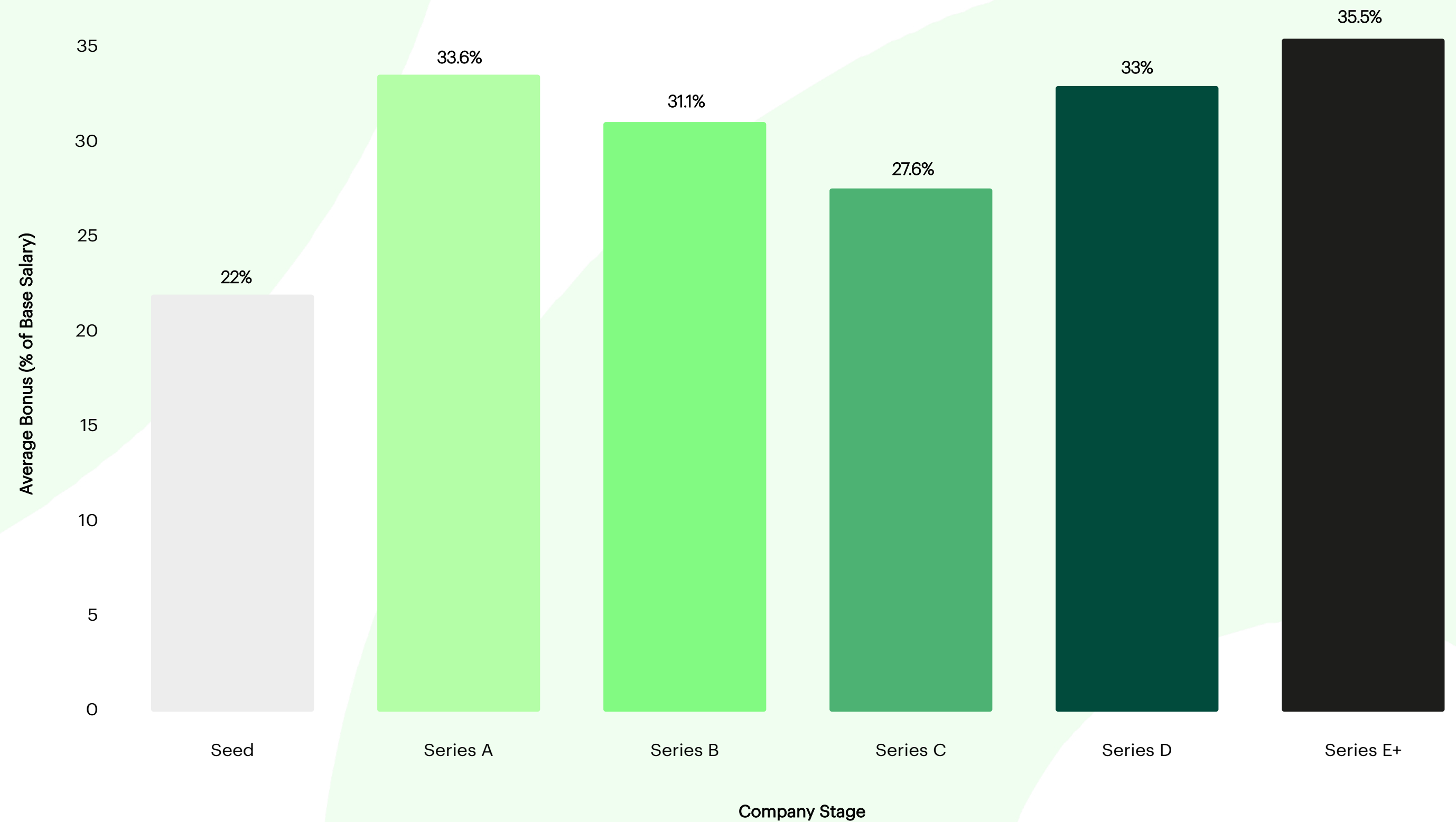
Among CFOs receiving bonuses, the compensation structure shows significant variation.

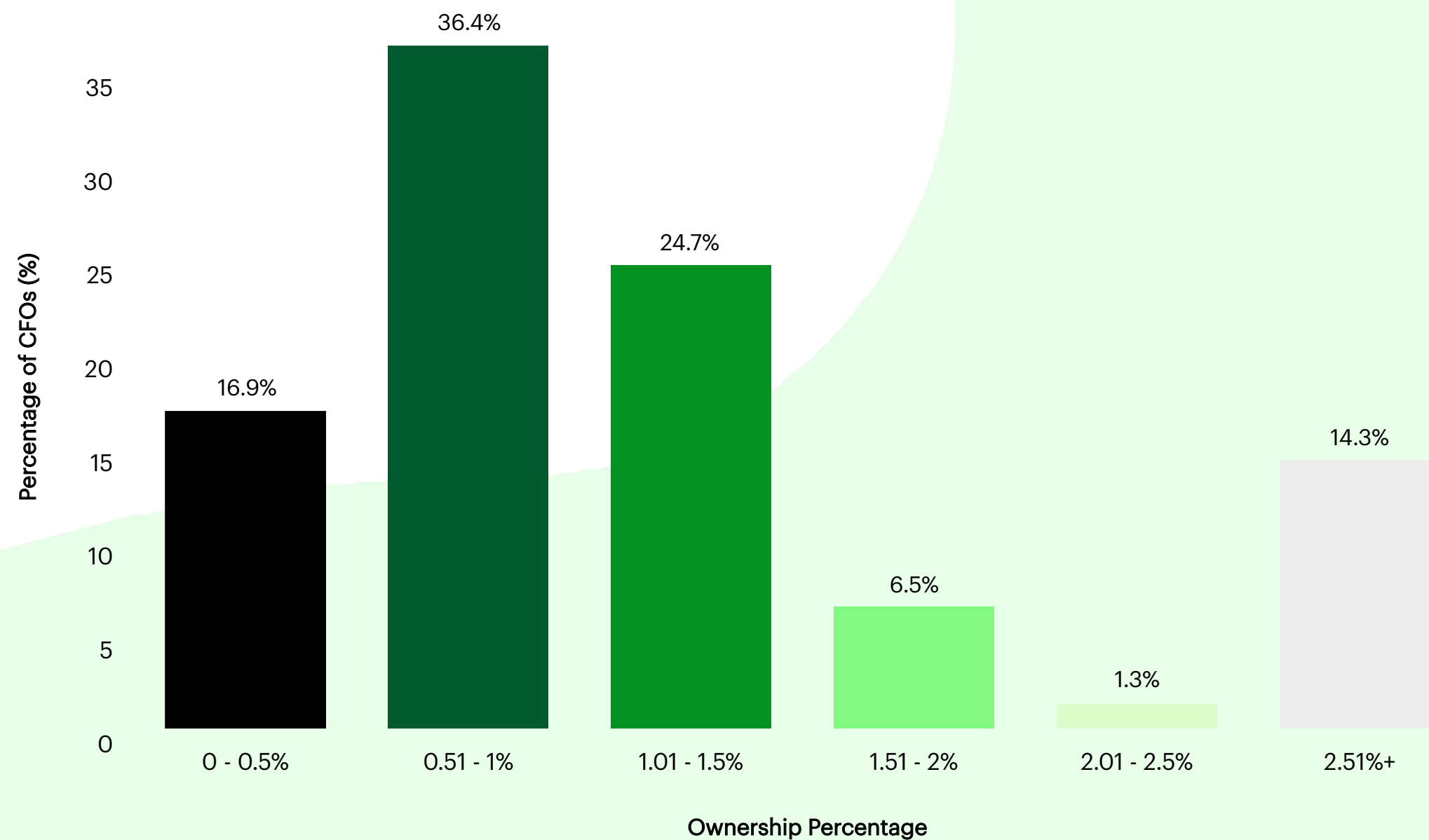
The most common range is 21-30% of base salary (29.9%), though a substantial portion (46.8%) receive bonuses of 31% or higher, indicating strong alignment between CFO compensation and company performance.

Seed-stage CFOs report the lowest average bonus at 22% of base salary, with zero CFOs at this stage receiving bonuses of 30% or more. In contrast, Series A CFOs show a dramatic jump to an average bonus of 33.6%, with 60% receiving bonuses of 30% or more. Series D CFOs demonstrate the strongest performance-based compensation, with 75% receiving bonuses of 30% or more.

Performance-based compensation is standard practice, with 81.1% of CFOs receiving bonuses.

Average CFO Bonus as Percentage of Base Salary by Business



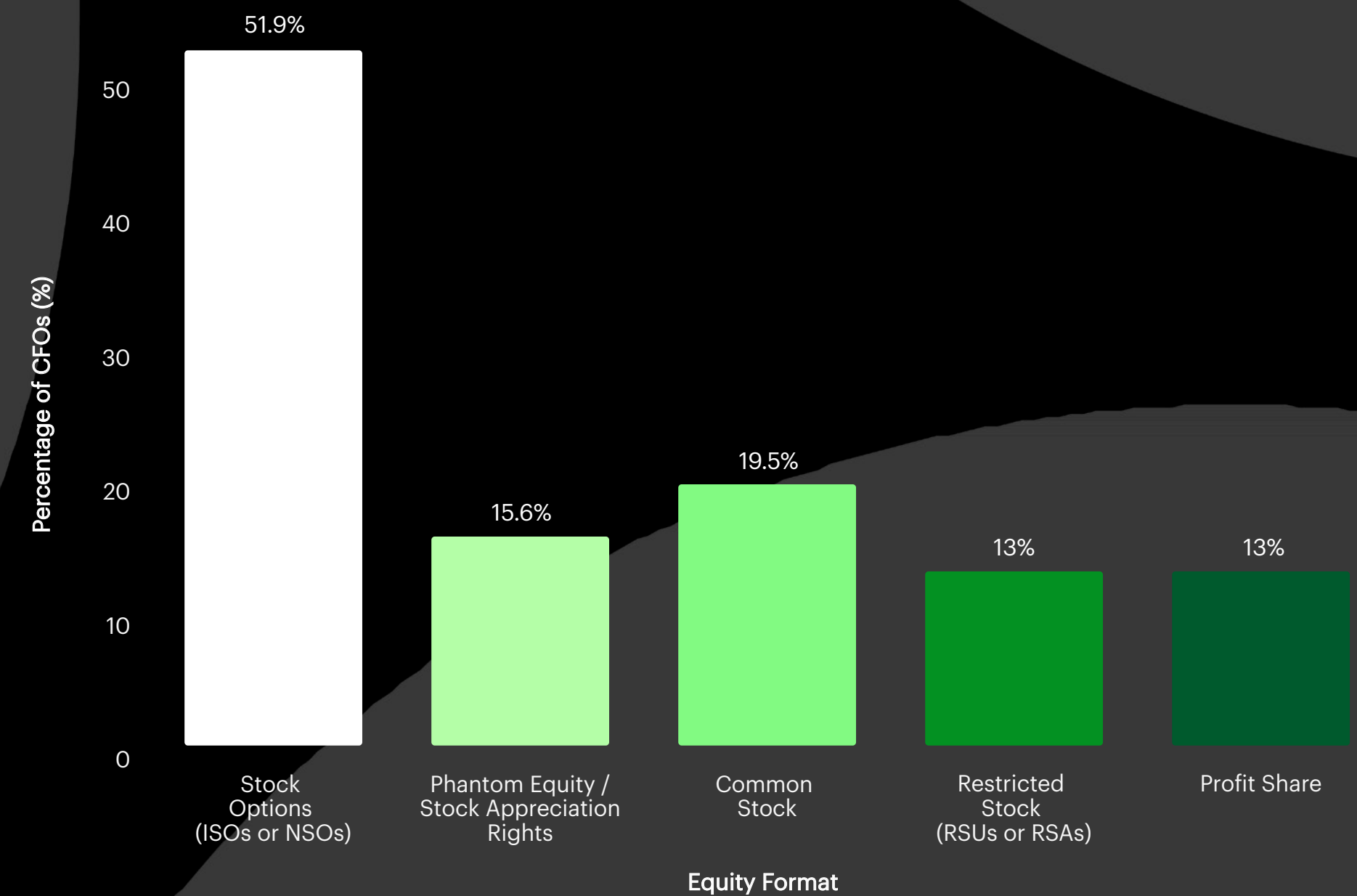


Over four-fifths of CFOs (81.1%) hold equity stakes in their current company.

CFO equity stakes vary significantly, with just over half (53.3%) holding between 0-1% of the company. However, 14.3% hold stakes exceeding 2.51%, predominantly representing founder-CFOs or very early hires at successful ventures.

CFO equity ownership shows a clear inverse relationship with company maturity. At seed

stage, 80.0% of CFOs hold stakes exceeding 2.51%, dropping sharply to 16.7% at Series A. By Series B and beyond, no CFOs in the survey hold stakes exceeding 2.51%, reflecting the natural dilution that occurs as companies raise additional capital and hire executive talent at later stages.

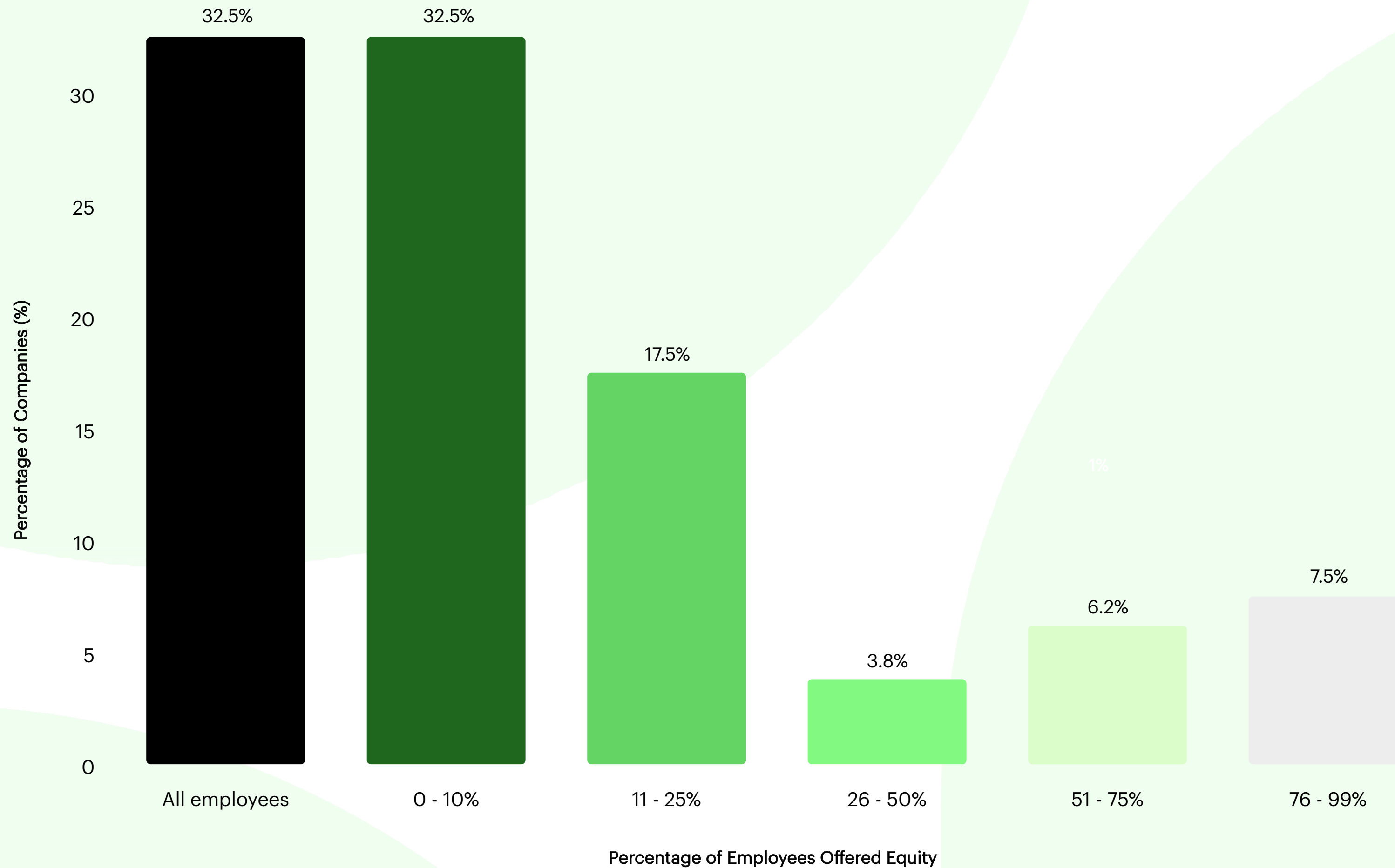


Stock options dominate as the preferred equity vehicle, with phantom equity and RSUs serving specialized structures.

Stock options (ISOs or NSOs) are the predominant equity vehicle at 51.9% of CFOs with equity, followed by common stock (19.5%), phantom equity arrangements (15.6%), and restricted stock (RSUs or RSAs) at 13%. The prevalence of options reflects

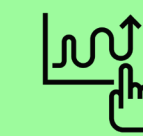
tax advantages and flexibility in granting equity without immediate dilution. Profit share arrangements represent 13%, typically found in partnership structures or private equity-backed entities.

Employee equity offerings are split down the middle: 32.5% provide equity to all employees, 32.5% to fewer than 10%.



The distribution between universal equity (all employees) and highly selective equity (0-10%) reveals a clear philosophical divide, with both approaches commanding exactly equal adoption. This perfect split represents two distinct compensation strategies: universal programs that aim to align all team members with long-term success, and selective programs that reserve equity for senior leaders and key contributors.

The middle ranges (11-75%) represent 27.5% of companies, indicating that while most firms (65%) choose one extreme or the other, over a quarter implement tiered equity programs that extend beyond top leadership but stop short of universal coverage.



Cap Table Management Frequency

Cap table update practices among CFOs show strong operational rigor, with quarterly updates being most common (31.6%), followed by monthly (25.3%). Only 12.6% of CFOs don't actively model their cap table, suggesting mature equity governance practices at most organizations. An additional 14.7% update only before funding rounds or major events, taking an event-driven rather than continuous approach.



Equity Management Challenges

CFOs identify employee education as their greatest equity management challenge (42.2%), followed by system complexity (33.7%) and compliance and legal issues (24.1%). These pain points highlight the operational burden of equity administration, with a particular emphasis on the communication challenge - many employees don't understand their equity's value, vesting schedules, or tax implications.



CFO Quotes



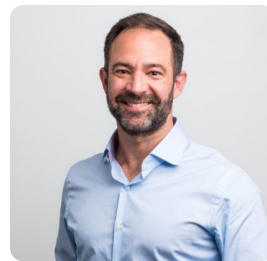
Sana Bukhari
SVP Finance, Black Duck

"AI is transforming the CFO role from a primarily transactional and compliance-focused function into a strategic, data-driven leadership role. Routine tasks like reconciliations, forecasting, and reporting are being automated, allowing CFOs to focus on real-time insights, scenario modeling, and enterprise-wide value creation. Over the next few years, CFOs will increasingly act as stewards of AI investments and governance, shaping both financial performance and organizational strategy through technology."



Manali Patel
SVP Finance, The Daily Beast

"In the next few years, the CFO role will evolve to be as much about leading through economic changes as through with numbers. The blend of human insight & predictive technology is where I think the biggest impact will come. With every technological advancement comes risks of data security, data ethics, transparency and governance and this is where I believe the CFO role and impact will be most crucial."



James Orsillo
CFO, Underscore.VC

"AI has transformed the way we work internally. It provides for faster research, earlier V1s, sanity check on data, and summarization of complex documents. I use AI 2-3 hours per day and it saves me 3x that amount of time. I predict that over time manual tasks will be automated with AI, and CFOs and finance orgs will spend more time analyzing data than manually creating it."



Mike Etheridge
CFO, Sureify Labs

"This is an exciting time to be a CFO as technology is continuing to enable increasing real-time insight. As an operator and as an investor, there are many new and evolving AI-driven platforms that are adding capabilities to accounting operations (faster close, translating contracts to invoices and JE's), financial planning (AI-powered flux explanations and predictive insight), and key metric reporting (highlighting outliers or areas of attention). All of these will continue to uplevel the office of the CFO and development of future leaders!"



Bob Krakauer
CFO, Arevon Energy

"AI tools are fundamentally improving the productivity of both mundane tasks and complex analytical functions, but the higher analytical tasks are challenging our data architecture to support the automation."

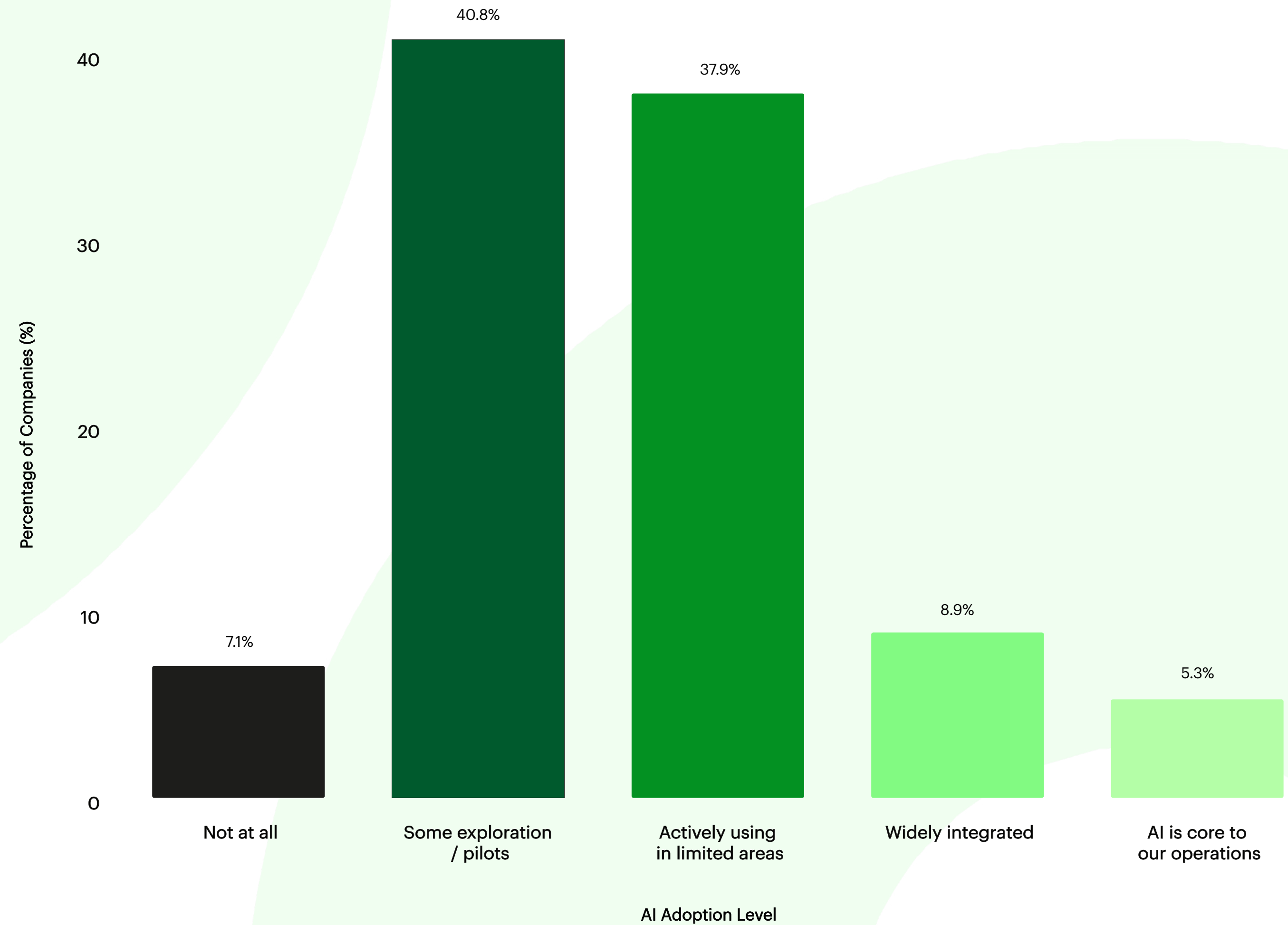


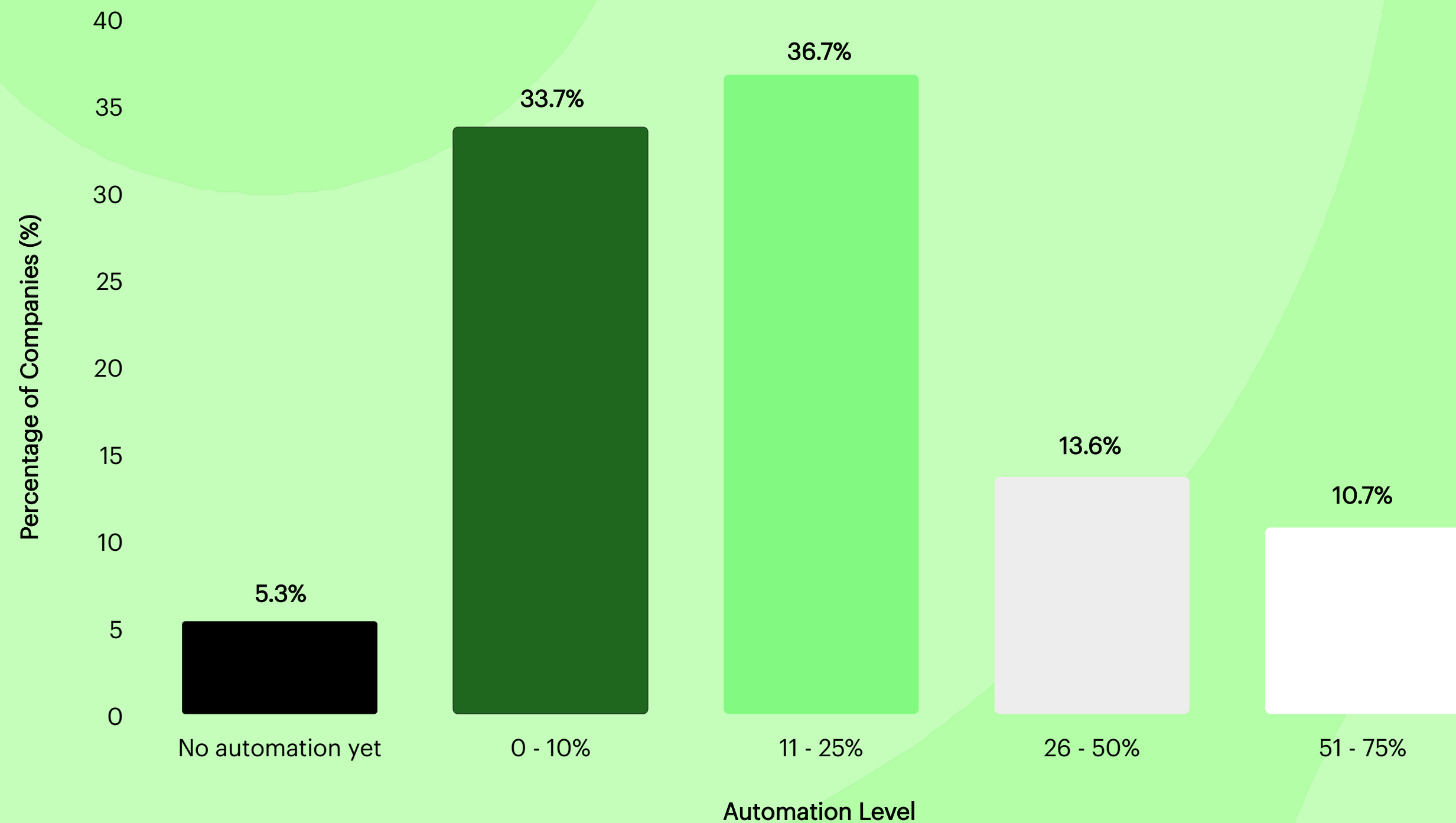
AI Adoption



The vast majority of companies (92.9%) report using AI in some capacity, while only 7.1% report no AI usage whatsoever.

Combined, 92.9% of companies are using AI in some capacity. However, just 14.2% have reached the 'widely integrated' or 'core to operations' stages, indicating that most organizations remain in experimental or limited deployment phases. This creates a 78.7 percentage point implementation gap between companies that have begun AI adoption and those that have achieved meaningful scale.



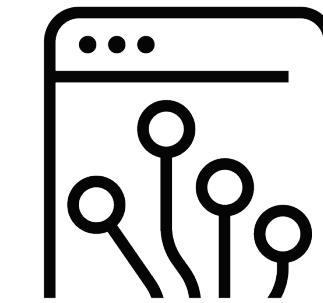


Financial automation remains in early stages, with the majority of companies having automated less than 25% of traditional financial reporting and analysis.

The concentration in the 11-25% range (36.7%) suggests most finance teams are in the early implementation phase. Just 5.3% report no automation, indicating that 94.7% have begun the automation journey to

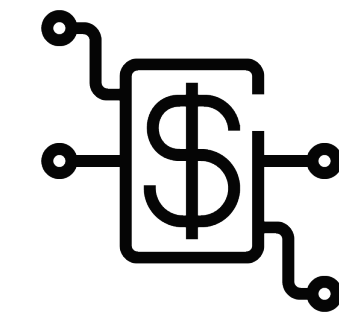
some degree. Series D companies show the highest concentration of minimal automation (57.1% at 0-10%), potentially indicating resource constraints or operational complexity at this growth stage.

AI Adoption Levels by Industry



SaaS

48% actively using, 35% in pilots, 13% with deep integration



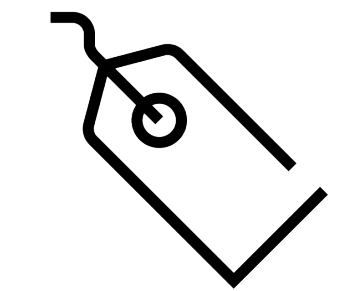
FinTech

25% actively using, 38% in pilots, 25% widely integrated (highest deep integration)



HealthTech

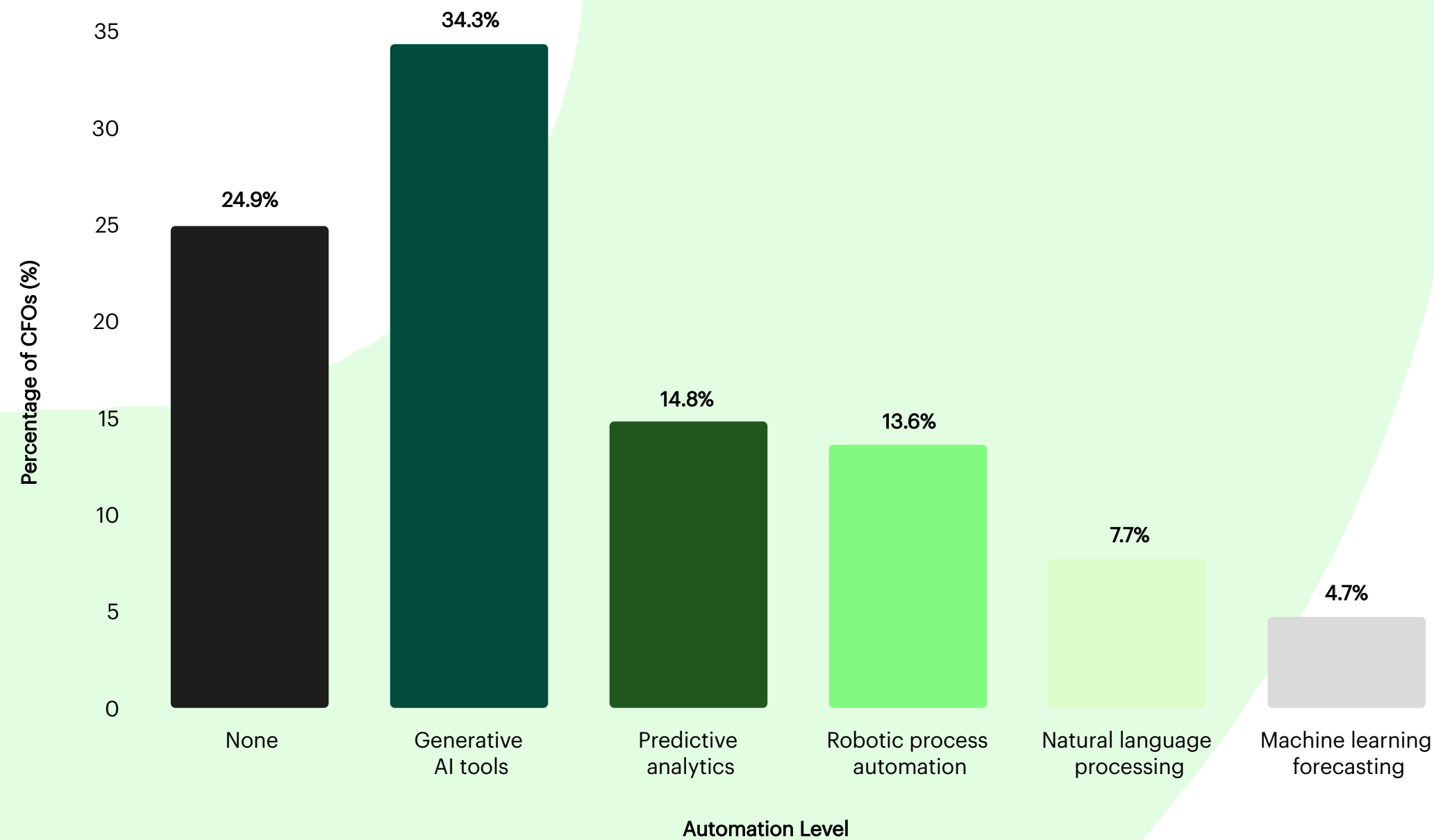
100% of survey respondents have adopted AI in some form (40% pilots, 40% active use, 20% wide integration)



Consumer

14% not using at all (highest non-adoption)

AI Technology

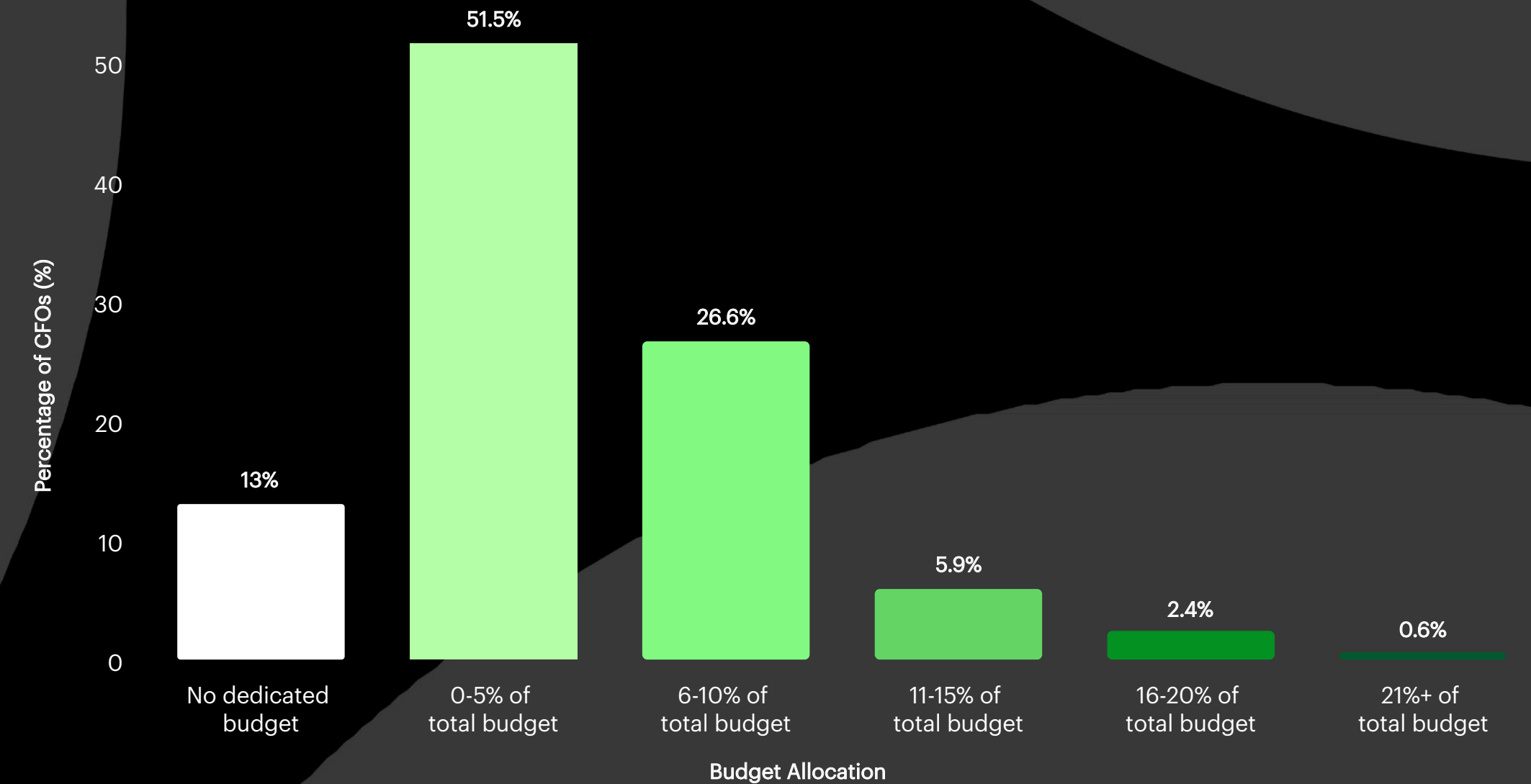


When asked what the primary AI technology impacting a company's financial leadership is, Generative AI tools came out on top.

Generative AI's 34.3% share reflects the technology's rapid emergence and accessibility to finance functions. The 24.9% reporting "none of the above" indicates that a significant portion of finance leaders have not yet identified a primary AI technology, despite broader company-wide AI adoption reported earlier.

Combined, traditional AI technologies (predictive analytics at 14.8%, robotic process automation at 13.6%, natural language processing at 7.7%, and machine learning forecasting at 4.7%) account for 40.8% - slightly more than generative AI alone. However, generative AI's dominance as a single technology category is notable given its recent emergence.

Budget Allocation



AI and technology infrastructure budgets remain modest, with the majority of companies allocating less than 10% of total budget to these initiatives.

78.1% allocate 10% or less of total budget to AI and technology infrastructure, while 13% have no dedicated AI budget at all. Only 8.9% dedicate more than 10% of budget, suggesting conservative investment despite widespread adoption rhetoric.

The Expected Impact of AI on the CFO Role

- CFOs overwhelmingly expect AI to transform their role, with 91.6% anticipating moderate to fundamental changes over the next 3-5 years.
- Only 8.3% expect minimal or no changes, indicating a majority belief that AI will substantially alter financial leadership.



CFO Interview

Michelle Hipwood CFO, Enfi

What decisions do CFOs need to make earlier than they typically do to avoid scaling pain later on?

The most critical early decision is establishing the right metrics framework and ensuring your data infrastructure can actually tell you where to invest. Too many early-stage CFOs focus on top-line ARR without understanding unit economics at a granular level. At EnFi, we had to get disciplined early about tracking margins by customer, by product feature, and by implementation type.

The second area is validating product-market fit through financial data, not just anecdotal feedback from sales. The data told us which customer segments had the strongest retention and expansion, which directly informed where we allocated sales and product resources.

Finally, investing in your data stack early is essential. I'm not talking about expensive enterprise software, I'm talking about building clean data pipelines so you can connect product usage to revenue outcomes, customer behavior to churn risk, and feature adoption to expansion opportunities. Without that foundation, you're making multi-million dollar bets based on intuition rather than evidence.

Which non-finance functions have the greatest impact on the effectiveness of the finance team, and why?

I don't think any single function has a greater impact than another. Finance sits in the middle of the organization, and our effectiveness comes from being a connector between GTM and Build. Our role is to let the data help tell the story and support investment decisions across both sides of the business.

What truly impacts finance team effectiveness is having a collaborative and trusting team environment across all functions. At EnFi, we've worked hard to create a culture where information flows freely in both directions. Finance isn't a gatekeeper; we're a partner helping everyone understand the trade-offs.

The key to success is alignment. When the entire leadership team is working from the same data, aligned on the same metrics, and trusting the same processes, hard decisions become much easier to make.

What is the biggest barrier to adopting new technology within finance, and how do you address it?

The biggest barrier isn't budget or availability of tools it's the implementation cost in terms of time and disruption. At a small, fast-growing company, the finance team is already stretched thin closing books, supporting fundraising, and providing analysis to the business. Taking a week to implement a new billing system or switch accounting platforms feels impossible when you're in the middle of month-end close.

The way I address this is by forcing myself to make the time anyway, and trying to be strategic about timing. Implement right after a board meeting when the pressure is lower, not right before, and involve the team in the decision so they understand the long-term benefit.

The other approach is starting small. Rather than a big-bang ERP implementation, we might automate one workflow at a time, start with expense management, then move to billing, then revenue recognition.



Looking ahead 3–5 years, how do you expect the scope of the CFO role to evolve?

I think we'll see CFOs become even more operationally involved across the business, particularly in revenue strategy and human capital management. The traditional view of the CFO as scorekeeper is already outdated—in 3-5 years, CFOs will be deeply embedded in designing pricing models, packaging, and customer segmentation based on unit economics, while also focusing on human capacity planning and effective management of staffing resources.

Things will become a lot more automated, and gathering insights will be significantly faster. The CFO's role will shift from building the models to ensuring data integrity and interpreting insights correctly. This acceleration will free up capacity for more strategic work focusing on questions like "should we enter this market?" or "how do we structure our investment for maximum return?"

Finally, CFOs will increasingly own operational metrics and data strategy, not just financial metrics. The CFO who can connect the dots between product engagement and revenue retention will be far more valuable than one who just reports GAAP financials.

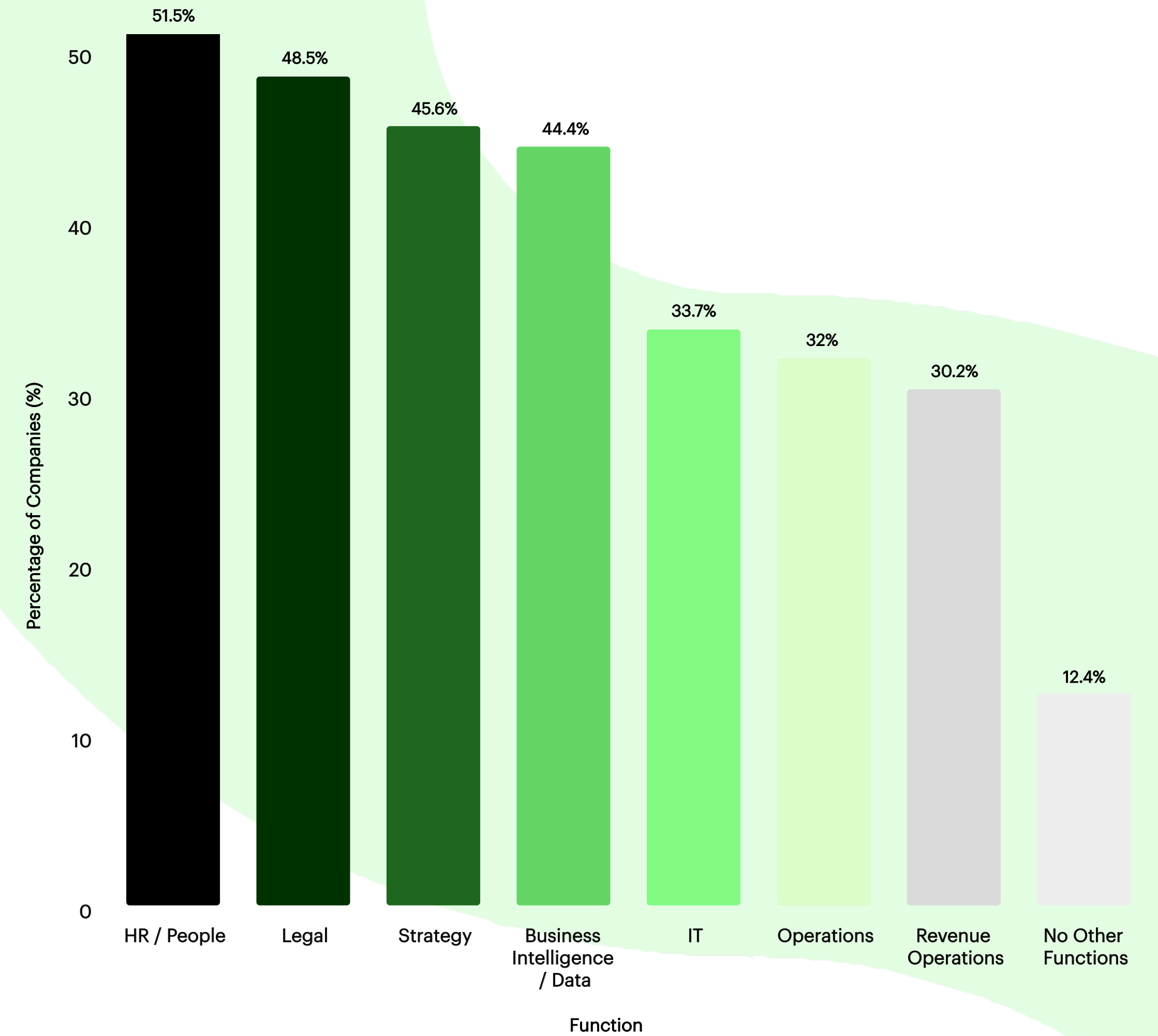


Business Growth & Financial Strategy



Modern CFOs extend far beyond traditional finance and accounting responsibilities, with 87.6% managing at least one additional function.

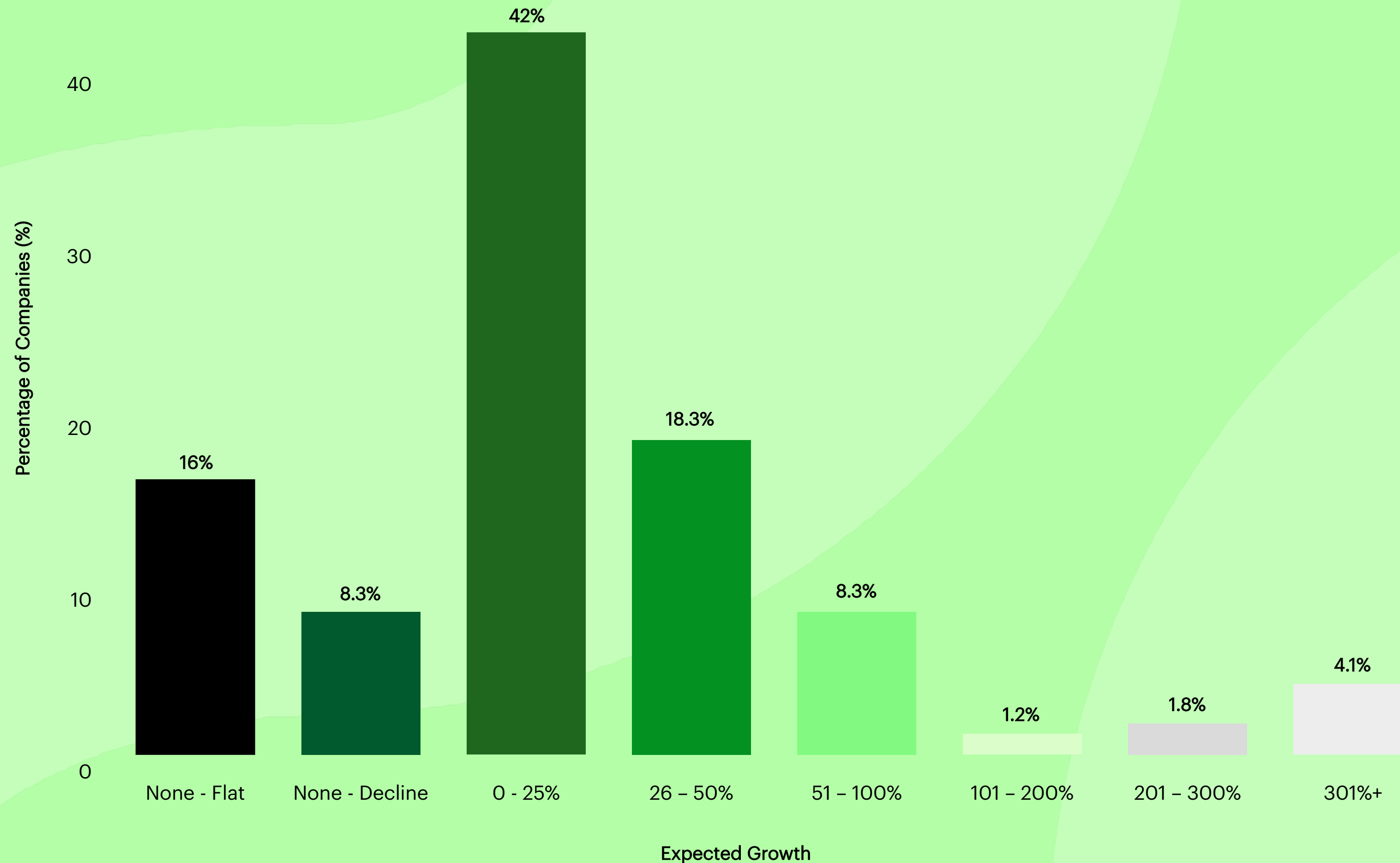
The breadth of the CFO role varies significantly by company size, with smaller companies requiring CFOs to wear multiple hats. HR/People (51.5%) emerges as the most commonly managed function, followed by Legal (48.5%) and Strategy (45.6%). Only 12.4% of CFOs manage no functions beyond finance and accounting, indicating that cross-functional leadership is now standard rather than exceptional.



Where do CFOs spend most of their time during the week?

Financial Operations (43.8%) is the primary focus for most CFOs, followed by Commercial Finance/FP&A (33.7%) as the top priority for others, and Strategy (22.5%) for the remainder.

Revenue growth expectations show a conservative outlook, with 42% of companies expecting modest growth of 0-25% and nearly one-quarter (24.2%) expecting flat or declining revenue.



Only 14.4% of companies expect high growth exceeding 50%, indicating that aggressive expansion plans are concentrated in a small minority.

Series A companies lead in growth expectations, with 38.1% expecting more than 50% revenue growth this year - the highest proportion at any stage. **Series E+ companies report zero companies expecting more than 50% revenue growth**, reflecting the reality that high growth becomes increasingly difficult at scale.

When CFOs prioritize growth, they overwhelmingly favor organic initiatives over acquisitive strategies. M&A represents just 6.8% of primary growth focus across all companies, meaning 93% are pursuing various forms of organic growth.

The most common organic growth strategies are:

- Scaling existing operations (34.2% selected "Organic Growth") - optimizing current business models and expanding within existing markets
- Developing new GTM strategies (18.6%) - entering new channels, customer segments, or repositioning market approach
- Diversifying product/service offerings (16.1%) - expanding the portfolio to capture more value
- Partnerships and Collaborations (8.7%) - leveraging external relationships for growth
- International expansion (6.8%) - entering new geographic markets
- R&D investment (3.7%) - innovating new capabilities

Growth strategies show distinct patterns based on revenue scale:

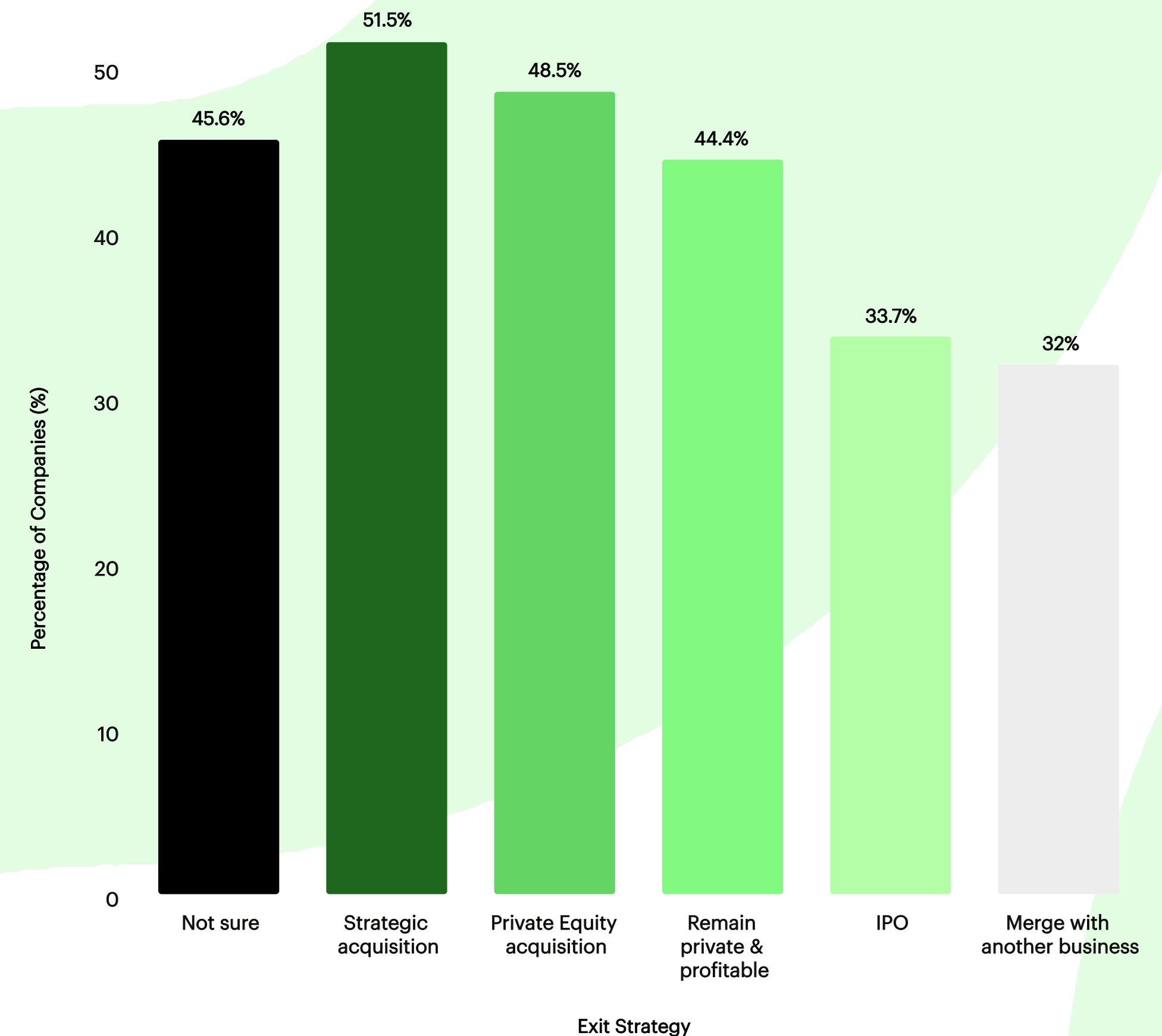
- Under \$1M: 40% focus on GTM strategy development
- \$1M-\$10M: 22.2% prioritize Diversifying offerings
- \$11M-\$50M: 27.9% focus on Organic Growth
- \$51M-\$100M: 47.4% prioritize Organic Growth
- \$101M+: 50% focus on Organic Growth

The data reveals a clear maturity curve: Early-stage companies focus on finding and expanding product-market fit through GTM development and diversification. As companies scale past \$50M in revenue, nearly half prioritize operational excellence and scaling existing models. M&A remains a niche strategy even at the largest scale, where companies have both the capability to execute acquisitions and the strategic need to maintain growth momentum.

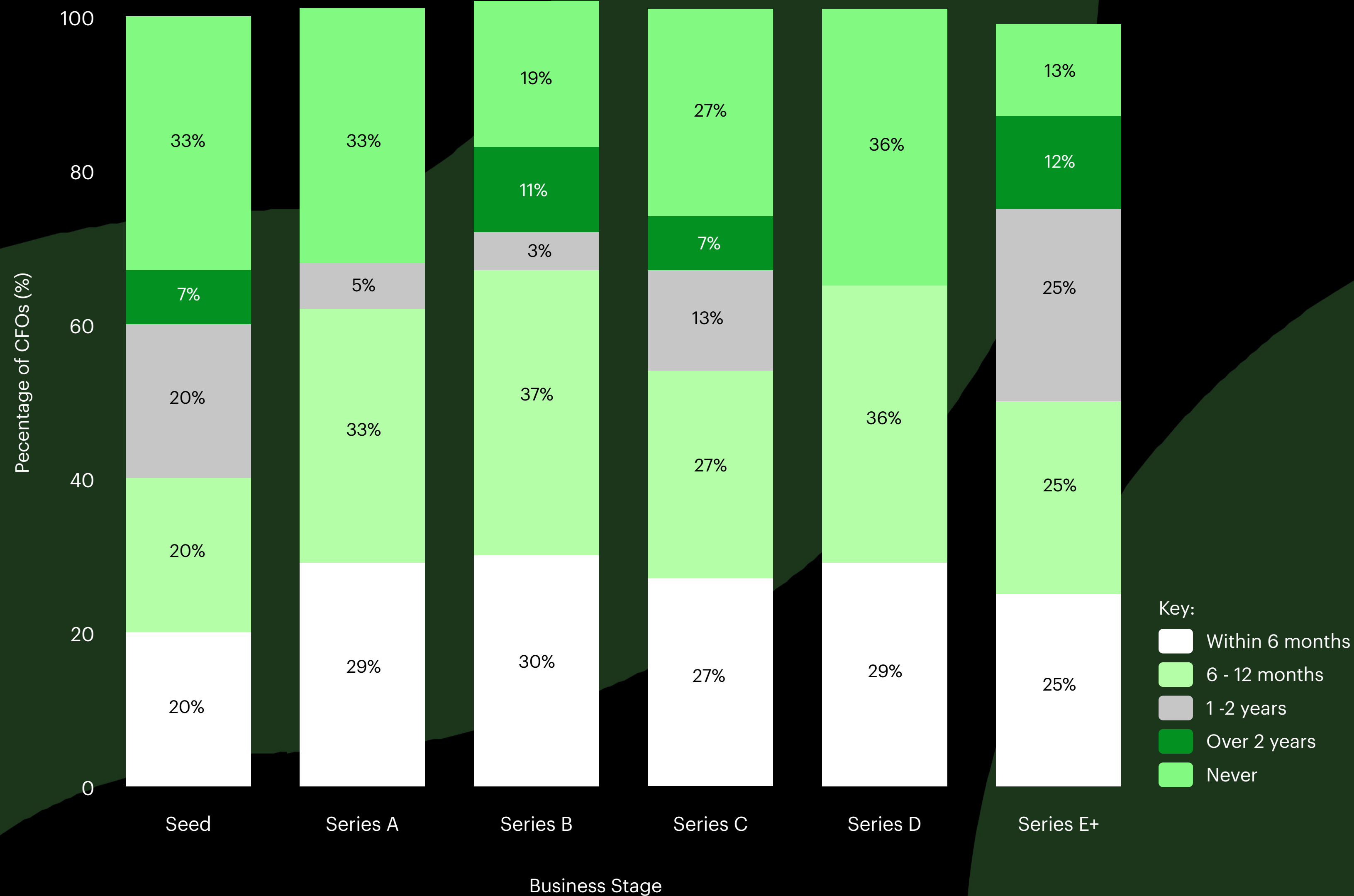
Exit Strategies & End Goals

Long-term exit strategies reveal that most companies envision external liquidity events, with strategic acquisition (43.2%) overwhelmingly preferred over other paths.

Just 7.7% of people surveyed said their company would target IPO, while 11.2% plan to remain private and profitable.



Last Internal Risk Assessment by Business Stage



Strategic Readiness & Governance



When asked how prepared they are for a due diligence process if a transaction or funding event arose, 72% of CFOs report being fully or mostly prepared.

While 72.2% claim due diligence readiness, 25.4% have never conducted an internal risk assessment. Of those who have conducted risk assessments, 56.8% assessed within the past year, while 17.8% last assessed over a year ago.

Risk assessment practices vary significantly by stage. Early-stage companies show 33.3% at Seed/Series A never conducting assessments, improving to 18.5% at Series B where 66.7% assess within the year. Series C rises to 26.7% never assessed, while Series D reaches 35.7% never assessed - higher than Series A despite greater company maturity. Series E+ shows 12.5% never assessed.

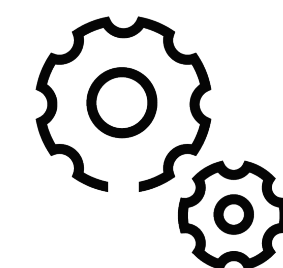
CFOs concentrate external advisory spend in three areas:



Specialized technical work (tax)
78.7%

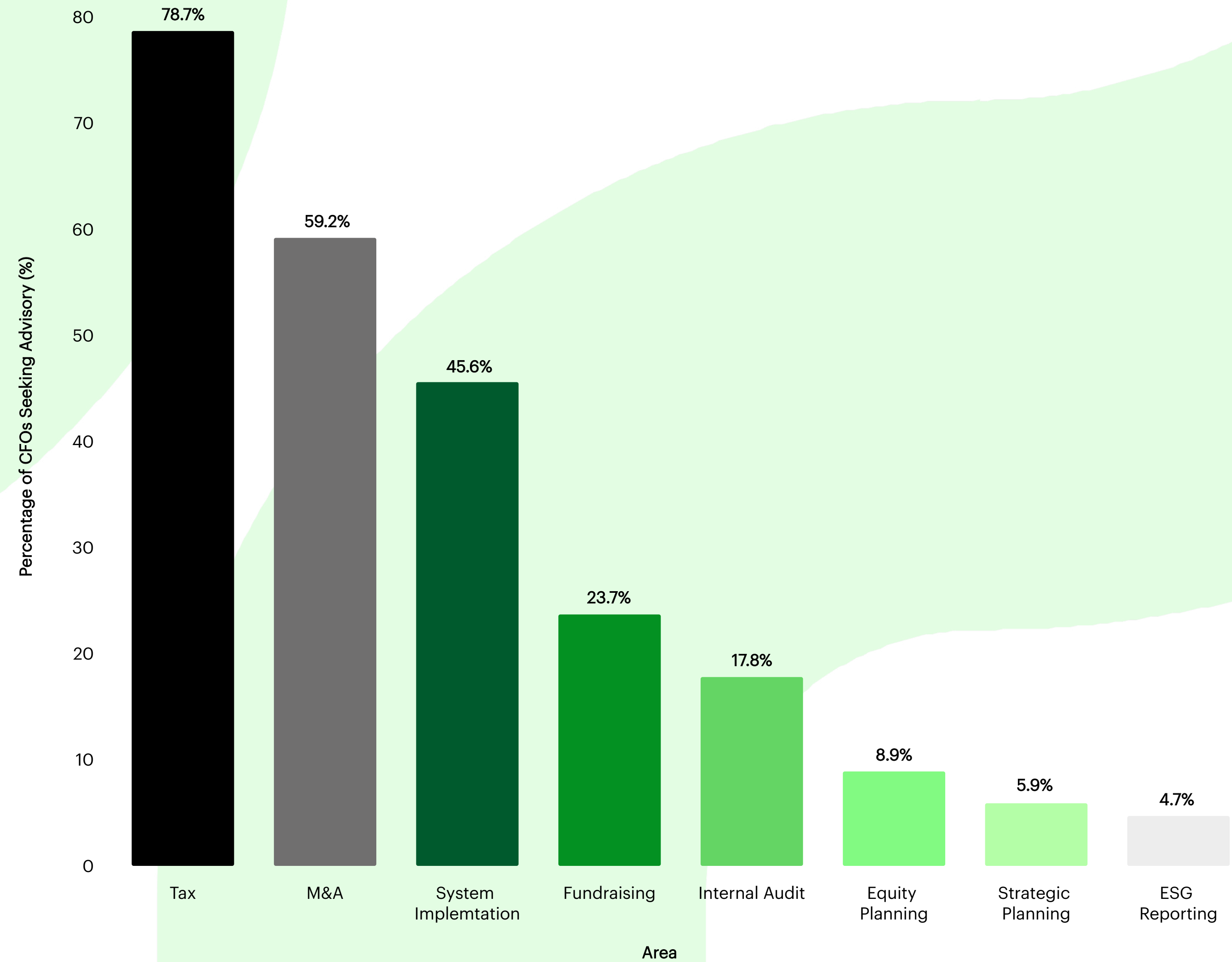


High-stakes transactions (M&A)
59.2%



Complex implementations
45.6%

Areas where CFOs seek third-party advisory





Talent & Retention



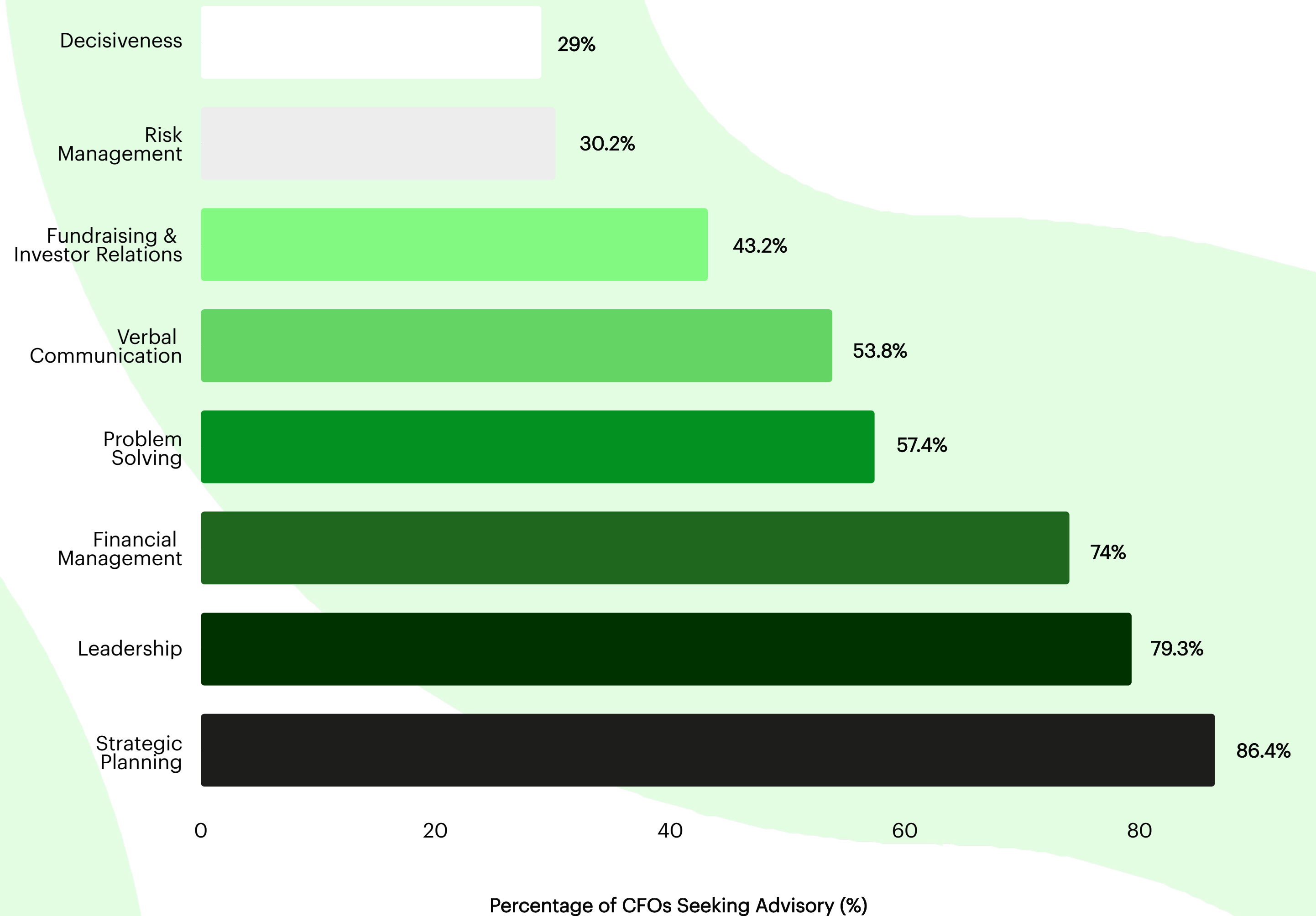
When asked to identify the top five essential skills and experiences for a successful CFO, respondents revealed clear priorities that emphasize both technical excellence and leadership capabilities.

The modern CFO profile reveals a decisive shift from technical expert to strategic leader. Strategic Planning (86.4%) and Leadership (79.3%) now outrank Financial Management (74%) as the most essential competencies, signaling the CFO's evolution from financial steward to executive partner.

Notably, Fundraising & Investor Relations (43.2%) ranks sixth, reflecting its particular importance in the venture-backed and growth-stage companies that comprise much of the survey base.

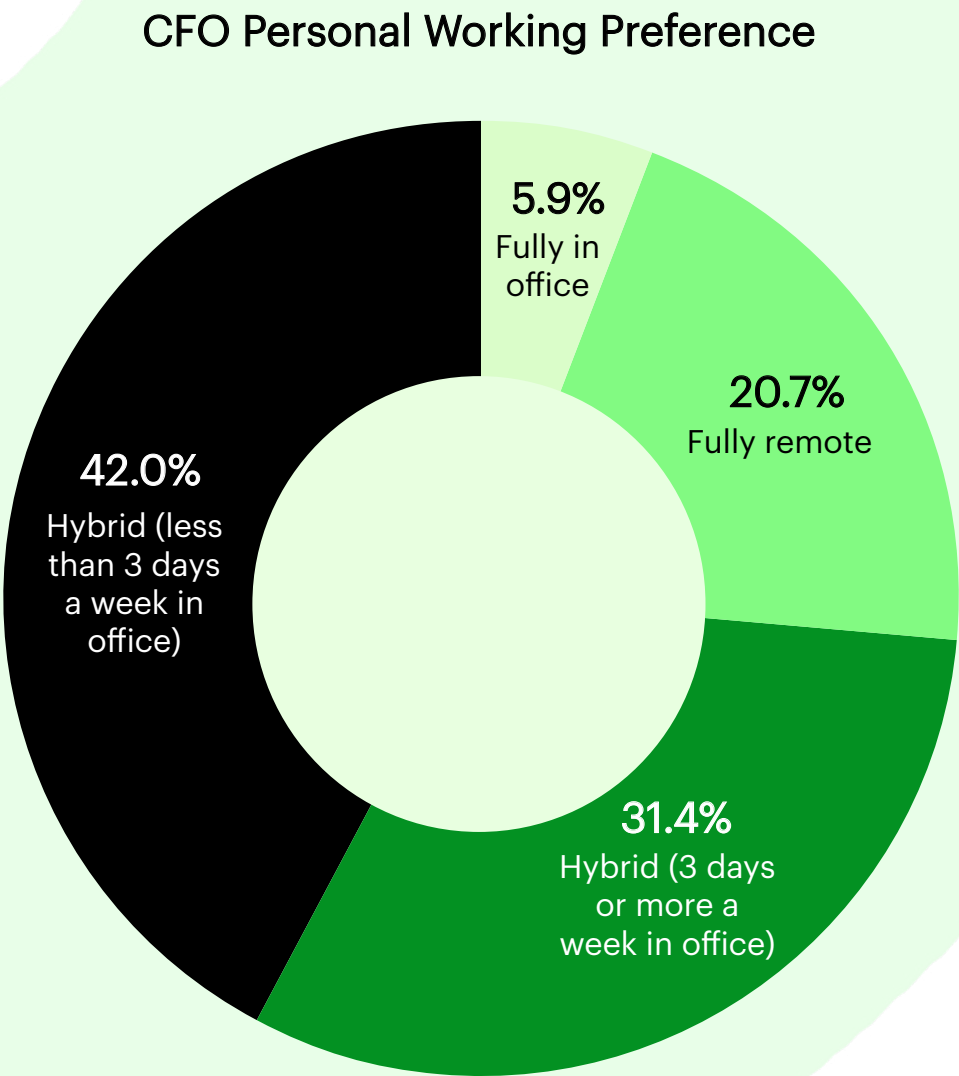
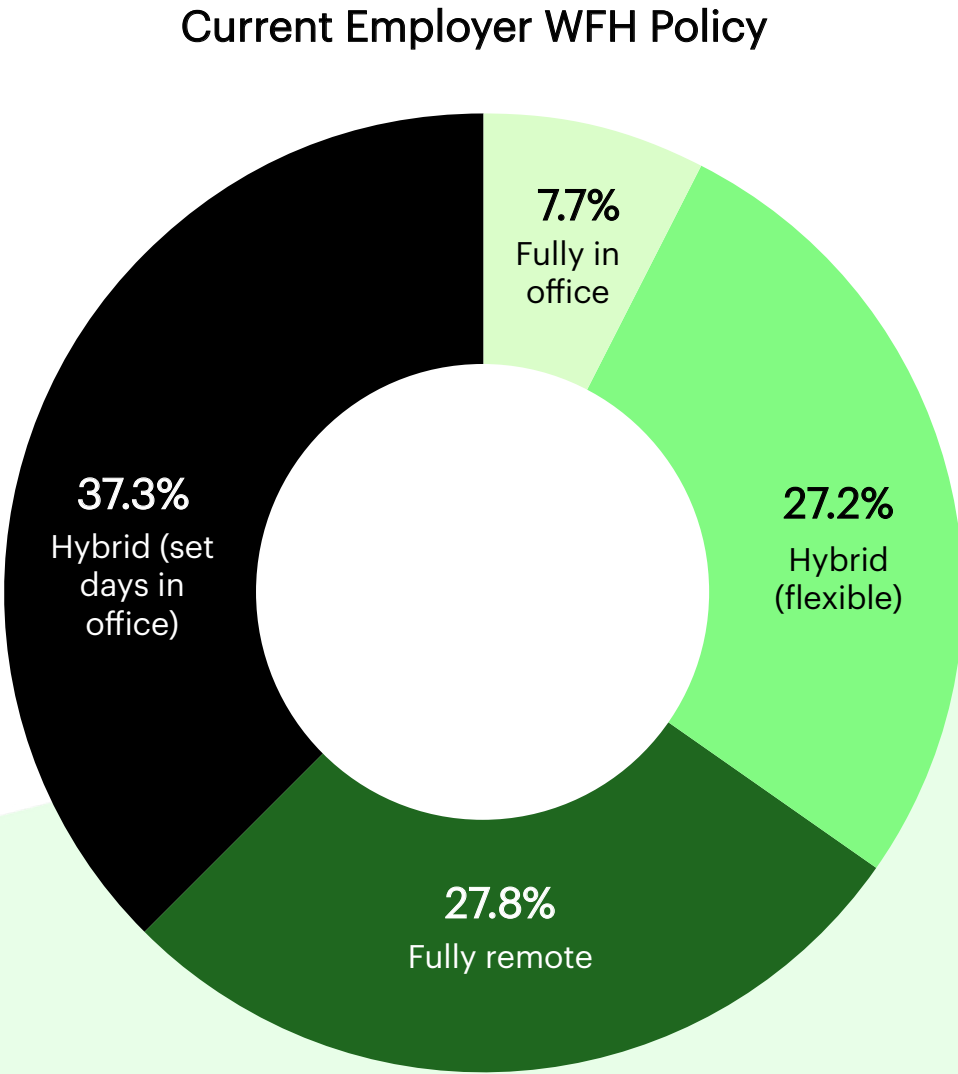
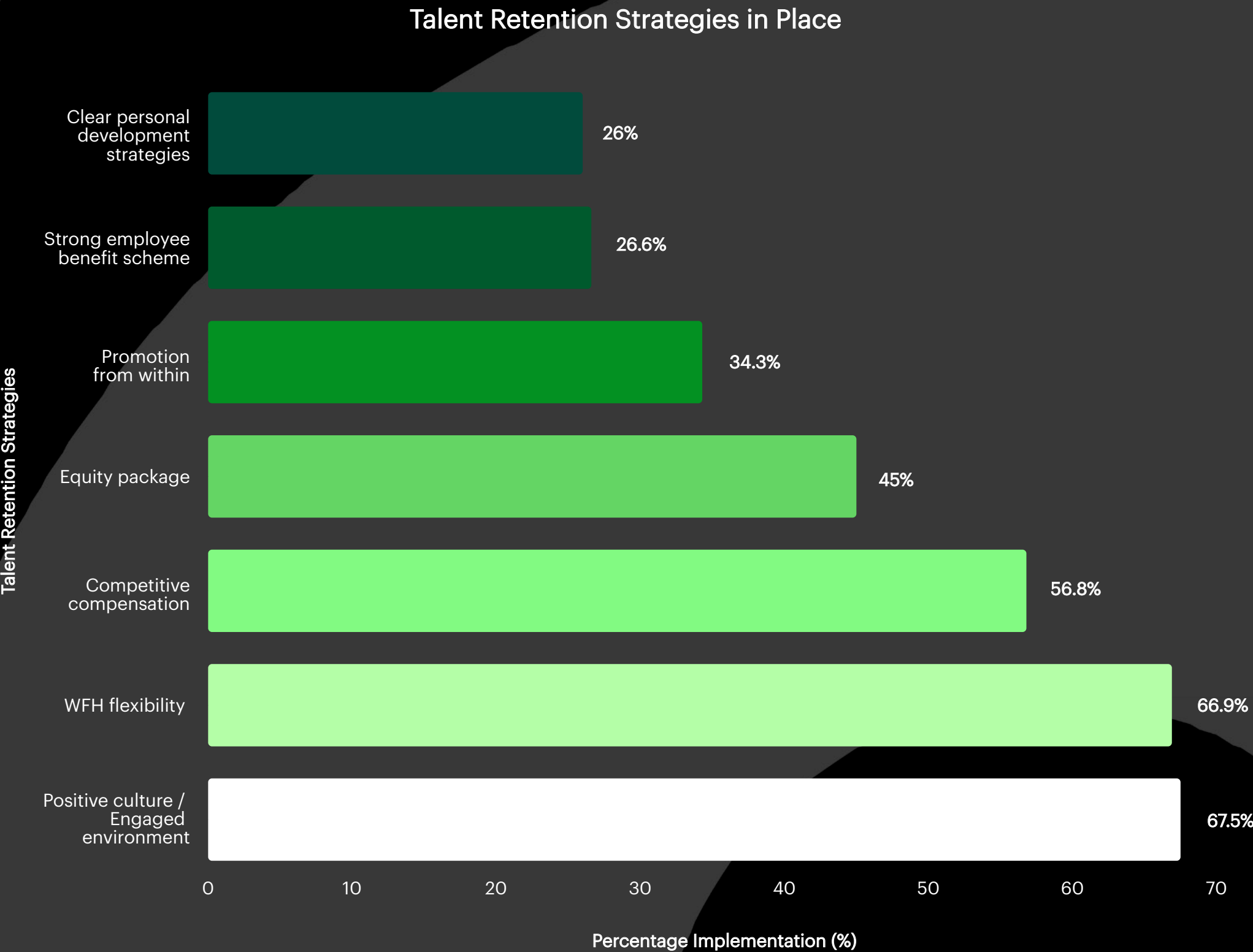
Top Essential Skills & Experience for CFOs

Essential Skills & Experience



Culture trumps compensation: 67.5% of organizations prioritize positive workplace environment and employee engagement as their primary retention strategy.

Work from home flexibility (66.9%) ranks nearly equal to culture, cementing hybrid/remote options as essential rather than perks. Notably, competitive compensation (56.8%) falls to third place, suggesting a fundamental shift in what drives retention.



Work Arrangements: Policy vs. Preference

The data reveals that 73.4% of CFOs prefer some form of hybrid arrangement, with a preference for less office time. This aligns closely with employer policies where 64.5% offer hybrid arrangements.

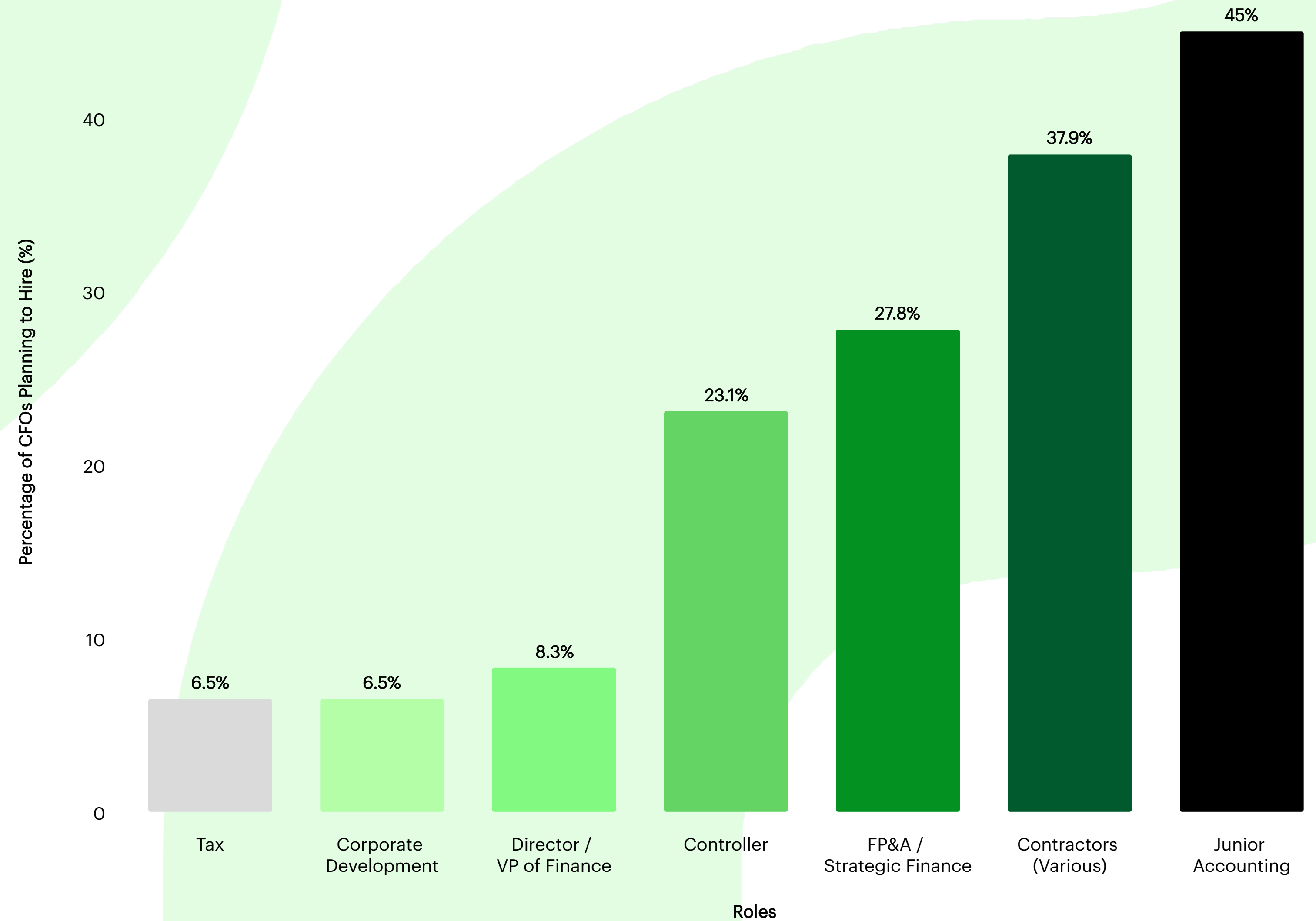
When asked whether they would consider allowing employees to work fully remotely to retain headcount, 62.1% said yes, 24.9% said maybe (case-by-case), and only 13% said no. This overwhelming openness to remote work demonstrates that flexibility is viewed as a critical retention tool, even among leadership that personally prefers hybrid arrangements.

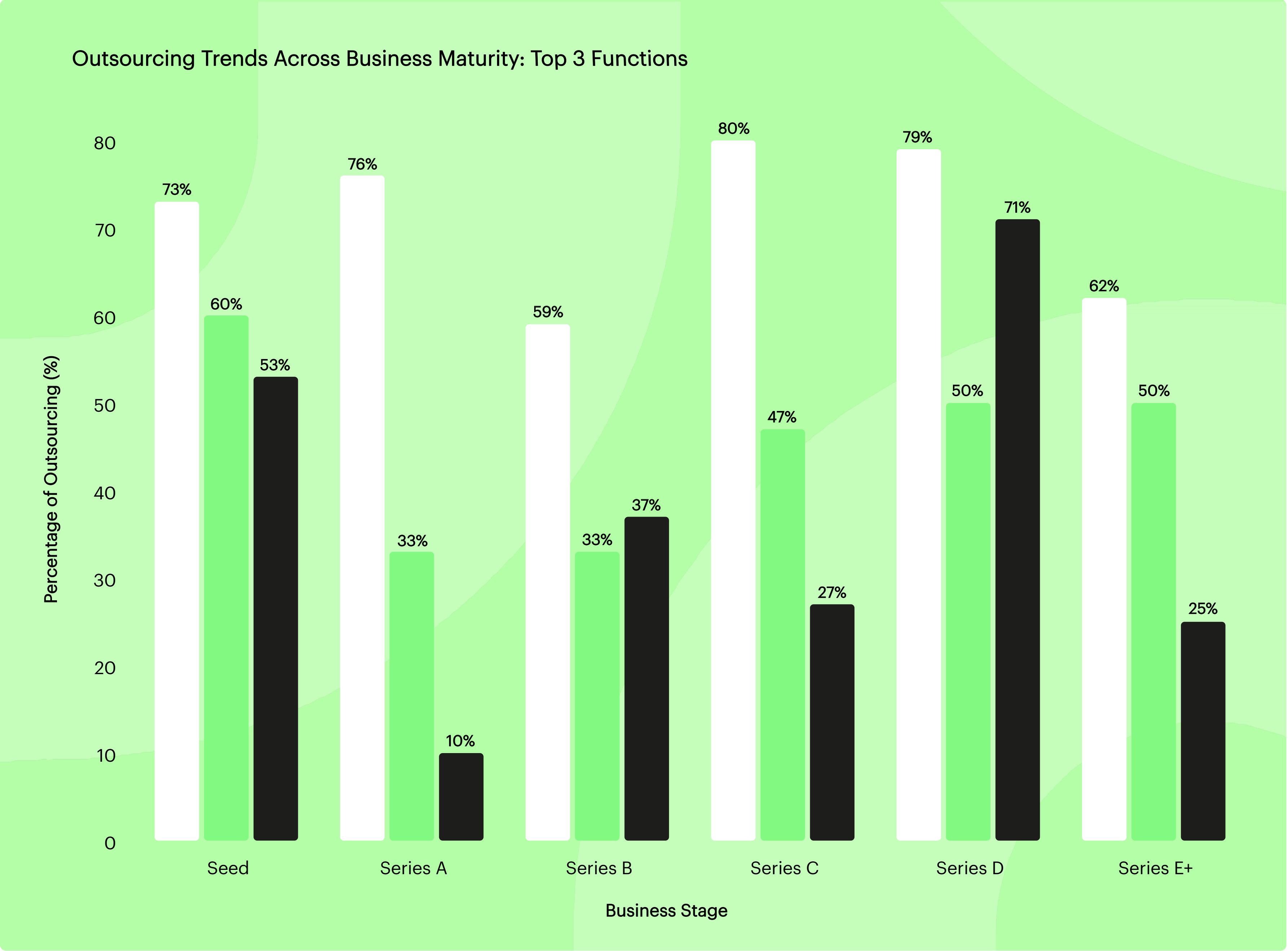
Roles Expected to Hire in the Next 12 Months



Survey respondents shared their hiring intentions for the next 12 months, revealing clear priorities in finance team expansion.

The hiring pattern suggests a pyramid structure: building out junior capacity (45%), adding specialized contractors (37.9%), strengthening mid-level analytical capabilities (27.8%), and selectively adding senior operations leadership (23.1%). The relatively low hiring for executive roles (8.3% for Director/VP, 6.5% for Corporate Development and Tax) indicates most organizations are focused on execution capacity rather than senior strategy roles.

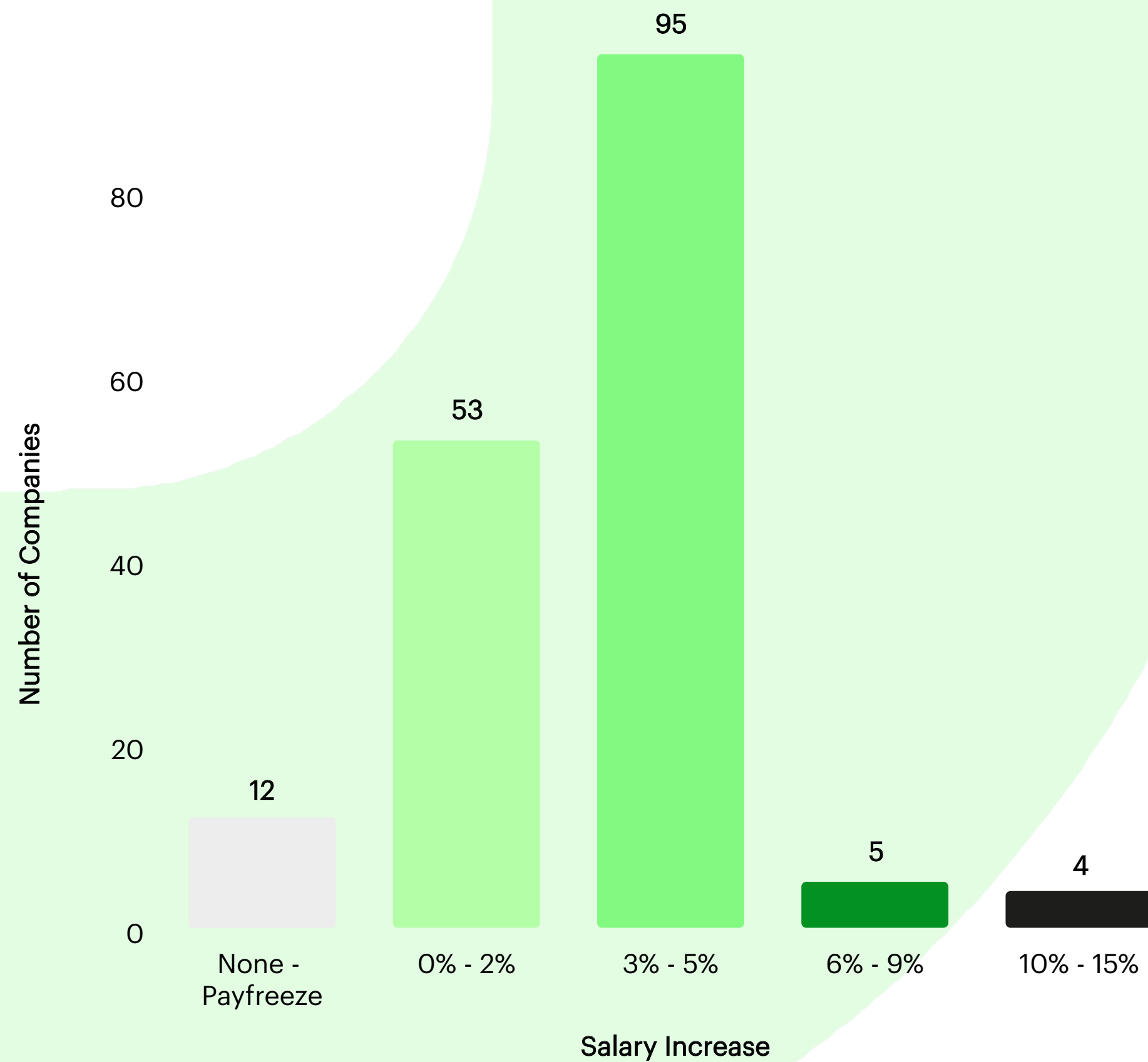




Strategic Outsourcing Evolves with Company Maturity

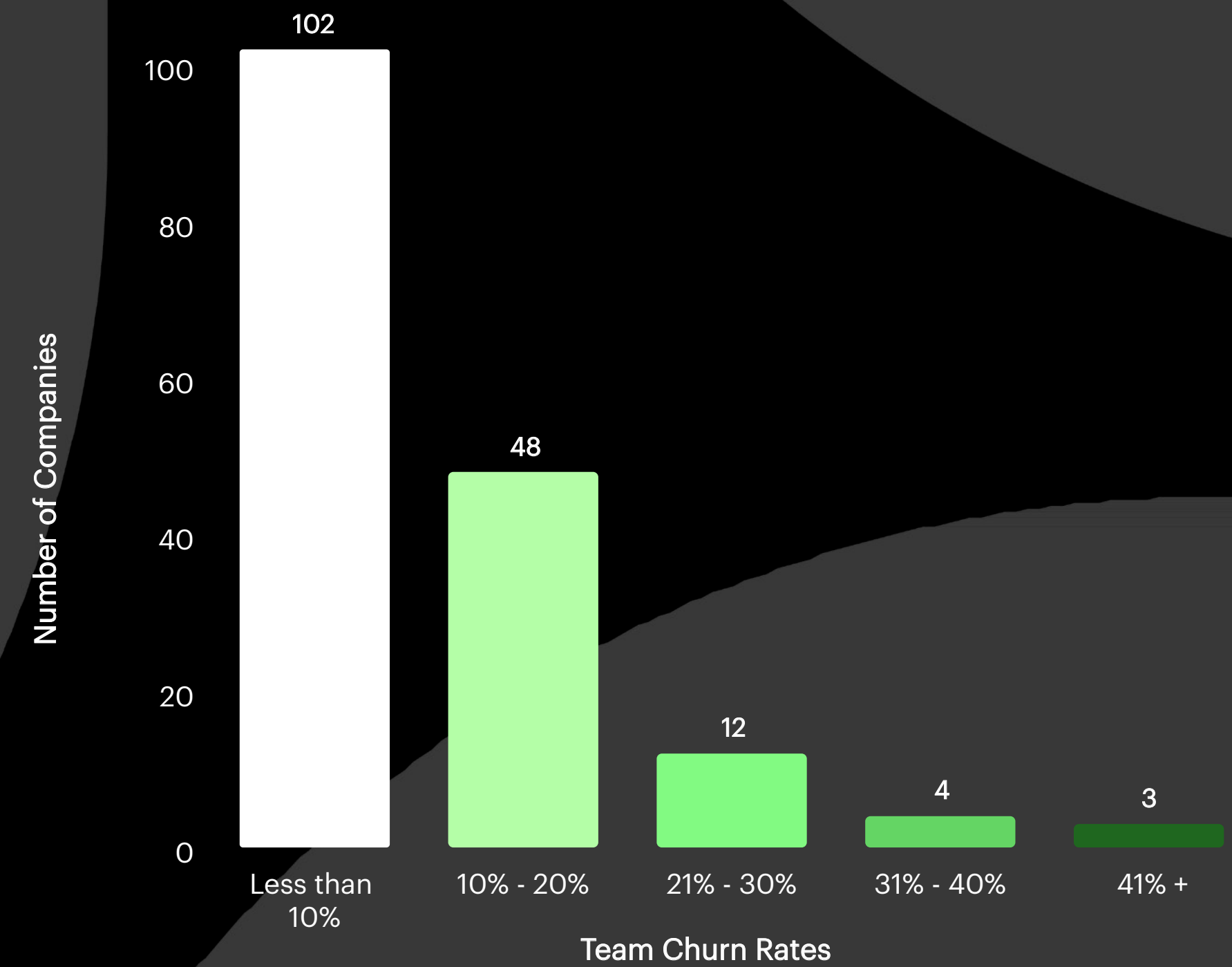
Seed-stage companies outsource heavily (53-73% across key functions), Series A-C firms internalize Payroll and Bookkeeping operations, with sharp drops in these functions, and Series D companies return to strategic outsourcing at scale (up to 71.4% for payroll).

Tax remains universally outsourced (59-80%) across all venture stages. Within Series A businesses, just 9.5% outsource payroll (vs 53.3% at Seed), showing intentional early investment in internal capabilities.



Salary increase expectations for the next 12 months

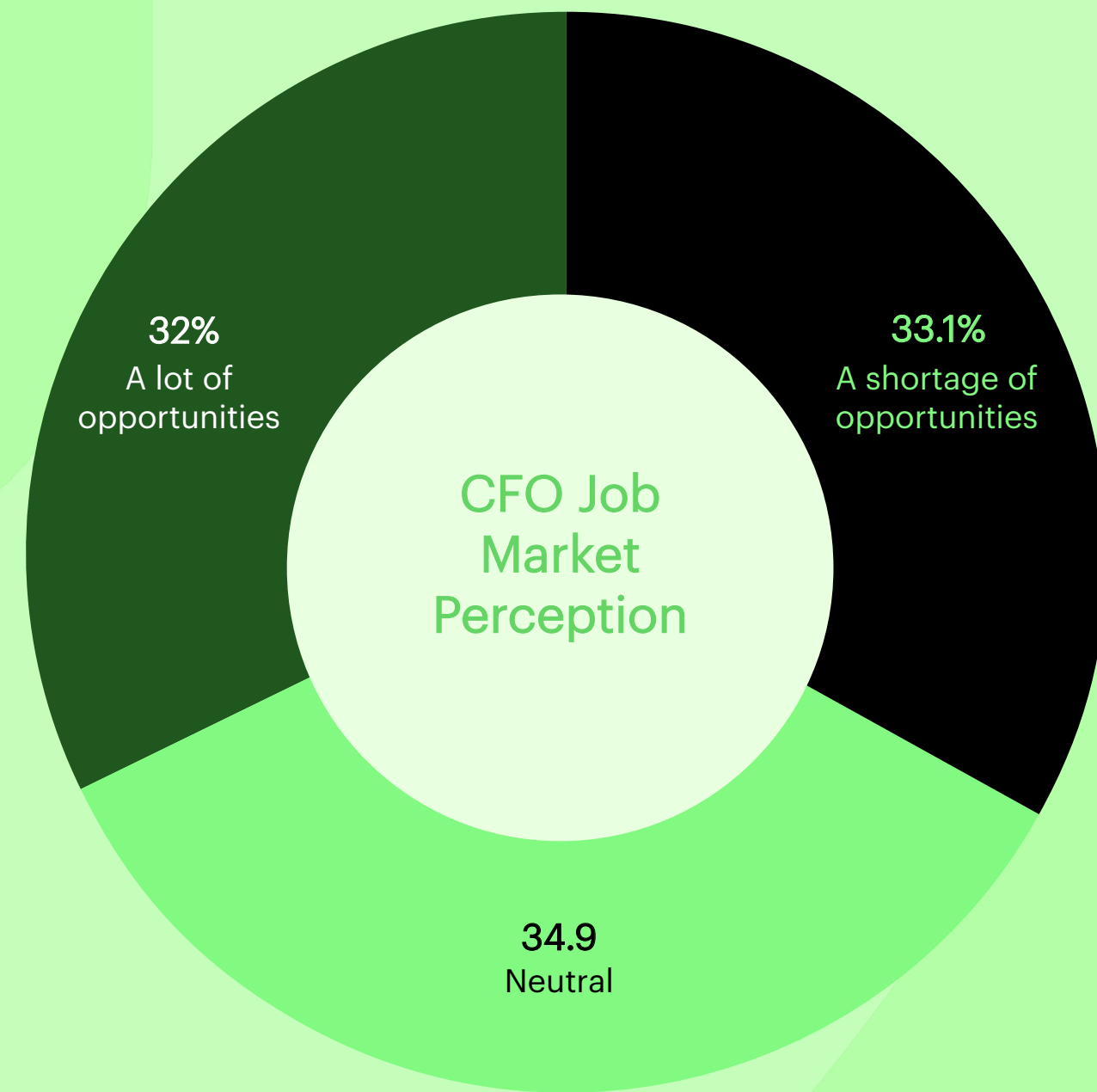
- The clear majority (56%) plan salary increases of 3-5%, representing a moderate but meaningful increase aligned with inflation targets.
- 7% plan pay freezes – a small but notable segment facing constraints.
- Notably, 88% of organizations plan some level of salary increase, demonstrating continued investment in talent retention.



Team churn rates experienced in the past 12 months

- 60% experienced churn below 10% which shows a strong retention performance by the majority.
- 89% of organizations maintained churn below 20%.
- The 11% experiencing churn above 20% represents organizations facing meaningful retention challenges that may require reassessment of their talent strategies.

The majority of CFO respondents (73%) benchmark financial performance against peers at least quarterly or more frequently, suggesting most CFOs maintain active awareness of competitive positioning. 7% of respondents benchmark performance monthly, whilst 14% do not benchmark at all.

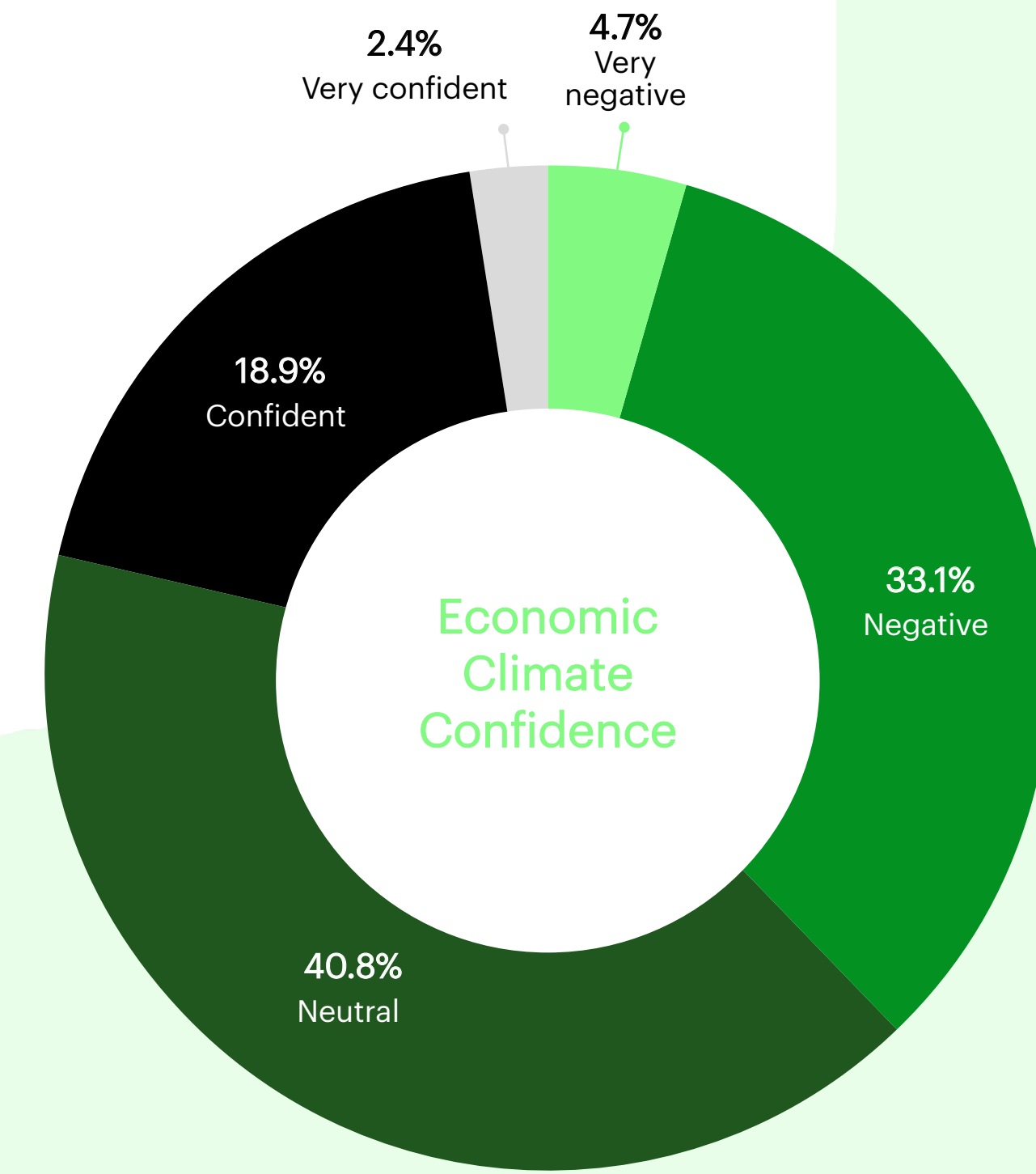


A Three-Way Split in the CFO Job Market

When asked about their perception of the US employment market for CFOs, respondents revealed a remarkably even three-way split:

- 34.9% view the market as neutral - neither abundant nor scarce in opportunities
- 33.1% see a shortage of opportunities - perceiving a challenging, competitive landscape
- 32% see a lot of opportunities - optimistic about demand for CFO talent

The lack of consensus indicates that opportunity perception varies dramatically based on factors such as industry sector, company stage, geographic location, and individual positioning.



Subdued Economic Confidence

While job market perceptions split evenly, CFO sentiment on the broader economic climate skews decidedly negative:

- 40.8% are Neutral - Taking a wait-and-see stance on economic conditions
- 33.1% are Negative - Expressing clear concern about economic headwinds
- 18.9% are Confident - Maintaining optimism despite uncertainties
- 4.7% are Very negative - Significantly concerned about economic prospects
- 2.4% are Very confident - Strongly positive about economic outlook

Aggregating these responses reveals that 78.6% of CFOs are either neutral or negative about the economic climate, with only 21.3% expressing confidence.

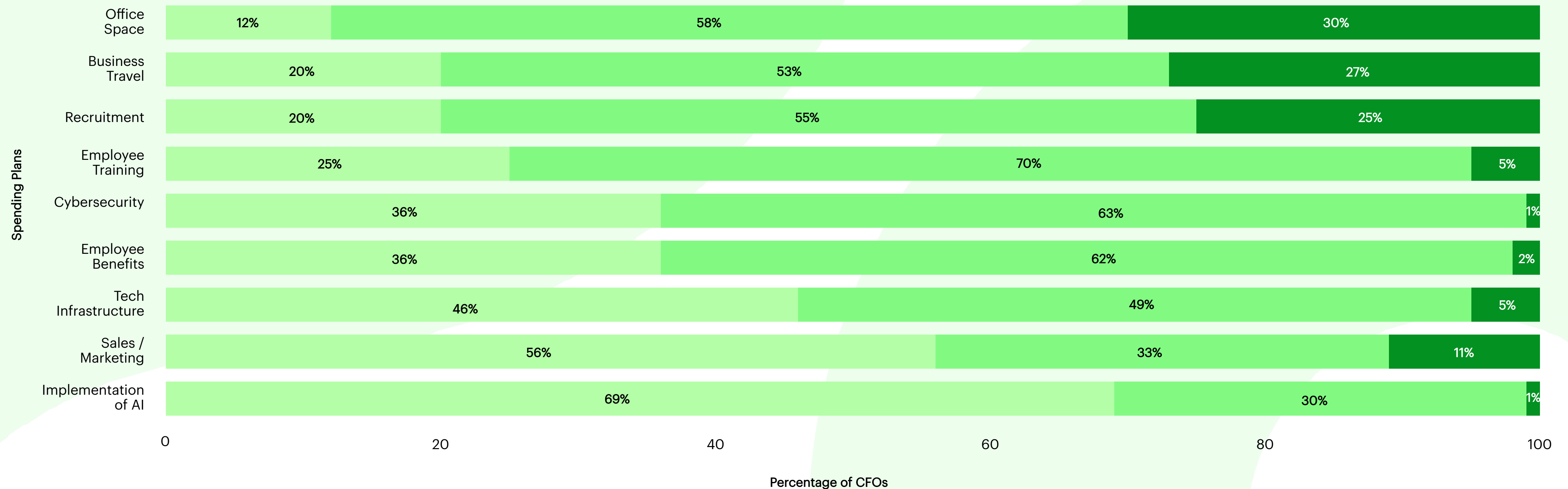
H2 2025 Spending Plans

While sentiment provides insight into CFO outlook, spending decisions reveal how that sentiment translates into actual business strategy. Despite subdued economic confidence, CFOs show clear willingness to invest in strategic priorities while cutting in other areas.

Implementation of AI dominates spending plans with a staggering +66.9% net sentiment (69% planning to increase, only 2% planning to decrease). The message is unambiguous: regardless of economic uncertainty, CFOs view AI investment as non-negotiable for competitive survival. Meanwhile, physical footprint is shrinking permanently - office space shows -17% net sentiment as hybrid work becomes structural, not temporary.

The overall spending pattern reveals selective growth: investing heavily in technology and customer acquisition while maintaining employee retention programs. Despite economic uncertainty, the majority of spending categories (6 of 9) show positive net sentiment, suggesting CFOs are leaning toward controlled growth rather than defensive retrenchment.

H2 2025 Spending Plans: Full Distribution





CFO Interview



Will Van Antwerp
CFO, Acoustic

What do you see as the most important capability of a modern CFO that wasn't essential five years ago?

At least in the SaaS space, the most important new capability is the ability to impose and sustain operating discipline across the organization. The environment today is fundamentally different than it was five years ago, and finance leaders are being asked to return to first principles: rigorous cash management, tight processes, rational systems, and lean teams. None of that is achievable without a CFO who can set a clear mandate for discipline and execute consistently against it.

Where do you see the greatest opportunities for modernization in the finance tech stack, and what impact could it have?

The obvious long-term answer is an AI-native ERP, and I do believe we will get there. In the nearer term, the biggest opportunity is a truly integrated finance stack: an ERP with native CPQ tightly connected to CRM on the front end and a modern FP&A platform on the back end. While versions of this exist today, many are legacy systems with bolted-on acquisitions that create friction rather than efficiency. A genuinely integrated platform would eliminate much of the manual work finance teams do to work around system limitations, freeing up significant time and improving speed, accuracy, and decision-making.

How do you balance building a high-performing team with maintaining flexibility and adaptability?

It starts with hiring. If you want a flexible, adaptable team, you need people who are flexible and adaptable, often those with well-rounded or non-traditional backgrounds who are motivated to grow and take on new challenges. From there, it's about setting clear performance expectations while giving teams room to adjust how they get there. That combination of high standards paired with autonomy allows the organization to stay adaptable without sacrificing execution.

Which external trends are having the greatest influence on your planning for the next 12 months?

AI is the external trend we're watching most closely. While a growing number of finance-specific tools are entering the market, most are still incremental rather than transformational. That said, a meaningful breakthrough feels inevitable, and our planning over the next 12 months is focused on staying ready: experimenting where it makes sense, building internal familiarity, and ensuring we can move quickly when the technology reaches an inflection point.

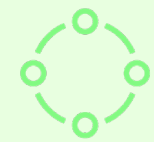


Methodology

Methodology

This report presents findings from the US CFO Survey 2025, conducted between August and October 2025. The survey gathered responses from 185 CFOs and finance leaders across the United States, providing comprehensive insights into compensation structures, AI adoption, business strategy, talent management, and market confidence. This report has been co-produced by Harmonic Finance, Fidelity Private Shares, and Baker Tilly.

Survey participants span the US business landscape, representing diverse industries, company stages, and growth trajectories:



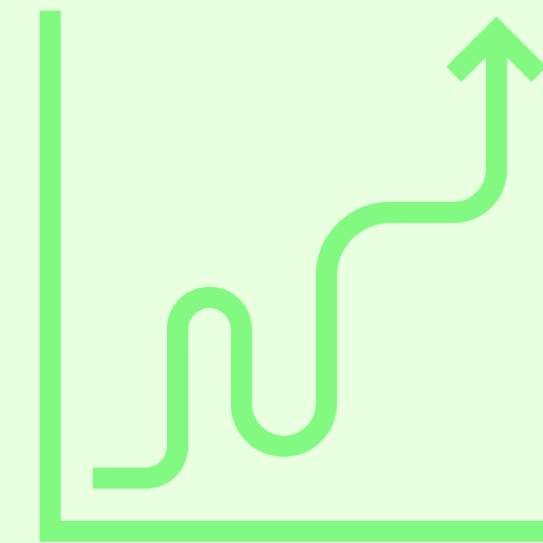
Industries

SaaS (28%), Tech (19%), Consumer (17%), Media/Music (9%), Climate (9%), and other sectors including Life Sciences and Energy (18%).



Funding History

40% have raised VC investment, 40% Private Equity, 19% angel investment, and 36% have utilized debt financing.



Company Stage

Early-stage Seed/Series A (21%), Series B+ (46%), with the remainder (33%) representing other stages including private equity-backed, bootstrapped, and alternative structures.



Leadership Profile

89% do not hold board seats, 81% hold equity in their current company.



Company Size

Respondents represented companies ranging from 0-20 employees to over 1,000 employees, with capital raised spanning from under \$1M to over \$201M.

Harmonic, Fidelity, and Baker Tilly are not affiliated.



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